The Tale of Two Lovers

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Established Relationship, Married Life, Infidelity, Cheating, Divorce, Angst, Emotional Hurt, Guilt, Starting Over, POV Alternating, POV Catra (She-Ra), POV Adora (She-Ra), Endgame Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Happy Ending

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by Litteratruc

Summary

Catra's cheeks were still red and she had a radiant expression as she gradually caught her breath after their sensual pleasures. Adora could have stayed there for hours just looking at her. In this instant, everything seemed perfect – well, almost.

There were some thin shadows in the back of her mind. For example, Catra was her best friend's wife and her own husband and kids were waiting for her at home.

It wasn't totally perfect, but what could go wrong?

The Only Right Thing to Do

When their naked, sweaty bodies split from each other, Adora landed on the other side of the bed. As a feeling of euphoria swept through her, she gradually caught her breath back, staring up at the ceiling. Turning on her side, she rested her head on her hand to enjoy the view in comfort. The hotel room was silent, except for Catra's swift breathing next to her. The colorless winter light streaming through the window gave the other woman's naked body an ethereal, almost spectral aspect.

Adora was mesmerized by her thin curves and slim, toned muscles. She was always starving to feel that soft skin under her hands, lips, tongue... She really loved to look at her short messy brown hair and her beautiful caramel complexion. Not to mention, her fascinating mismatched eyes, sky blue and light amber. The brunette was definitely beautiful.

"Princess, you kill me," Catra gasped, still lying on her back, staring at the ceiling.

"I guess you liked my new move then," Adora replied in a smug voice, grinning at the compliment.

"Where did you get that?"

"A lady must keep some secrets."

Catra snorted with a laugh, "Sure, that's what you are."

Catra glanced at her and flashed her a faint smile. A wave of intense emotion ran through Adora's full body at the sight of that blooming face.

Finally, her many hours of online research had finally paid off; she had impressed Catra. Adora adjusted her position to be more comfortable. Her long blond hair encircled a friendly face with deep blue eyes. Her eyes were particularly bright in that moment,

as she admired the other woman. She had an athletic body and a fair complexion.

The brunette’s cheeks were still red, framing her radiant expression. Adora could stay there for hours, just looking at her. It was just her and Catra for a while, the rest of the world didn’t matter. A precious moment for them. Adora couldn’t stop enjoying it.

Really, in this kind of moment, everything seemed perfect. Or almost perfect. There were always some shadows in the back of her mind. As much as she loved being there with Catra, she never could forget about uncomfortable realities for too long. For example, Catra was her best friend’s wife. Besides, her own beloved family – her husband and children – waited for her at home. All the lies, betrayals and vows broken to be with her lover…

In recent weeks, these trivial details had been growing in Adora's mind. A feeling of guilt overwhelmed her more and more everyday, as she thought about their situation and her family. It broke her inside in many ways and she couldn't bear it anymore. At the same time, every moment spent with Catra filled her with such joy. Whatever, she had to be strong. She had to put an end to this relationship. She was sad about what that involved, but it was for the best.

It didn’t seem fair to tell Catra right now, just after their shared moment of passion. To be honest, it seemed like the worst possible moment. But she had to take immediate action, or she wasn’t sure she would have the strength later. If she had been less cowardly, she would have done it before they met at the hotel, before they had taken the room, before sleeping with her. But she was craving to touch her, to smell her, and to taste her once more. She was delaying the inevitable moment, admiring her one last time.

"Catra," Adora awkwardly said, after a while. "We can’t continue like this."

"You're right," Catra commented in a cheerful voice, turning her blooming face toward her. "With your new move, we need a room with a king size bed next time."

"No, no, I mean between us," Adora clarified, alternately pointing at them both with a guilty look. Catra stared at her thoughtfully without a word, so she continued, "I can't take it any longer, you know I-"

"Please, Dora, I know exactly what you mean. This isn't the first time we've had this conversation."

Throughout their two-year-long secret relationship, Adora had already stopped, or at least tried to stop, this several times. However, her will hadn't always been equal to her intention. She had been weak before, but things were different this time. Her choice was made, and nothing would change her mind. She knew it was difficult for Catra to understand, but she had to accept the reality. It was the best way for them both, even though her lover didn't see it at that moment.

"We need to stop. You know I love my husband. I can't do this to my family any longer," Adora said in a still tender but firm voice, shaking her head and frowning slightly.

"I love my wife. But I love you too."

"Don't say things like that."

Catra reached out her hand to caress Adora's cheek, "I just say how I feel. These feelings aren't incompatible."

"Stop it! I'm sorry, but it's over."

Standing up quickly, Adora started looking around for her clothes. She grabbed her underwear from the floor, and hastily put it on. Then, she rushed across the room to take her creased sweater from a chair next to the bathroom. She avoided glancing at Catra who didn't move from the bed, staring at her with a faint smile. All her willpower was focused on doing the right thing.

“If you say so,” Catra replied carelessly, putting her hands behind her head.

“I would have preferred to spare you this, but I have to do the right thing,” Adora explained, genuinely sorry, as she looked around for her pants.

“Don’t worry about me, princess. Besides, you’ve still got my number.”

“You don’t understand. It’s different this time. It’s over. I’m serious.”

“Sure, you’re serious.”

Catra seemed to be in such denial it was painful for Adora to watch. She had strong feelings for the brunette and didn’t want to hurt her. However, she couldn’t afford to take so many risks with her family. There was too much to lose for her and for Catra. One of them had to take responsibility and bring this mistake to an end. Even though they were always careful, the situation had become too hazardous. Her conscience had tormented her for too long.

“You know it's better for both of us,” Adora justified herself, while she looked for her blue jeans under the bed.

“Whatever. I won’t argue with you when you’re like this,” Catra said, yawning and giving her an indifferent look. “What about next week?”

Holding up her pants, Adora stood up and frowned at the brunette. She didn’t want to play this game, there was no next week for them. “I know it's hard to accept, but we won’t-”, she began with a touch of annoyance.

Catra groaned, interrupting her, “Calm down Dora. I meant for New Year’s Eve. Should we bring anything?”

Amid their discussion, Adora had completely forgotten about New Year's Eve. Catra and her wife Glimmer would spend it with them like they did every year. Glimmer had been her best friend since college and the couples remained close.

Even though she couldn't meet with Catra as they were now, they would still have to see each other regularly. Adora felt a pinch in her chest at the thought, but she pushed the emotion away. It wasn't a problem. After all, they were responsible adults; they could deal with their clumsy history.

"No, we'll take care of everything," Adora replied, as she put her jeans on.

"Okay cool, I'll tell Glim. She was ready to bake something for dessert," the brunette said, flashing a wry smile.

"I'd rather not have one of her desserts."

"No one wants that."

Glimmer's cooking skills had been a subject of jokes for years, but Adora wasn't really in a mood to laugh right now. She felt melancholy rise in her, as she stared at Catra still lying on the bed. She sensed this was the last time they would be together in this magic intimacy. The idea almost hurt physically. Shaking herself out of her thoughts, she reached for her coat at the door. She put her hand on the door handle and hesitated for one second.

"I didn't want it to end this way, I'm sorry. But I hope you'll understand one day," Adora said in a trembling voice, opening the door.

"Dora," Catra called after her gently.

"If the situation was different, maybe we could have been together. I don't know," Adora turned to the brunette, her lips pursed in a thin line and her eyes wet.

"Maybe princess, but don't forget."

“What?”

“We need a king size next time.”

Adora didn’t have the strength to respond and just shook her head sadly. When she closed the door, the brunette was still chuckling to herself. She loved that laugh so much and felt her heart leap in her chest. Resting her head against the door, she took a few deep breaths to calm herself. She hadn’t meant to hurt Catra, but she saw no other way forward. Her only wish was that Catra wouldn't have too much trouble accepting reality.

Walking down the corridor of the hotel, Adora felt like part of her life was ending. Spending those moments with Catra the past two years had been a magical interlude in her daily life. Her feelings for Catra were deeper than she could admit, even to herself. The heavy weight on her chest at the moment proved it. But she knew time would help. Christmas was coming in a few days, so she could spend time with her family and forget about anything else.

This New Year would bring a fresh start for her, and she hoped for her lover, or rather ex-lover, too. As she exited the elevator, she had almost convinced herself. She paid for the room at the reception, even though it wasn’t her turn. She owed that to Catra at least .

When she stepped out onto the street, the cold hit her and she pulled her coat tighter around her. The snow had begun to fall and was already coating the ground. Winter weather had always relaxed her. It was bracing and helped her to forget everything. Despite the cold, she stayed awhile, gazing at the trees and the mountains. A bit relieved, she then slowly headed to her car.

Just Incredibly Fortunate

As Adora closed the room door, Catra couldn't hold back a chuckle. Lying in the bed, she pulled the sheet over her to warm herself and looked at the door with a slight smile. She could easily imagine the troubled expression on the blonde's face on the other side. It probably wasn't the best time to make fun of her lover, but she couldn't help herself.

Adora was always so dramatic in these moments. Over the two last years, this was the seventh, or maybe eighth, time the blonde had played the breakup scene for her. Catra had been taken aback the first time, but she knew her too well to worry now. From the blonde's guilty look, she had felt it coming for weeks and had just waited for the dam to collapse.

Every few months, her lover decided to stop everything, but it never lasted more than a week or two. It was her way of coping with their relationship and Catra couldn't blame her. At first, she had also spent many sleepless nights thinking about their situation. However, she was better at keeping her conscience quiet than the blonde. With the busy Christmas period they were both facing, Catra gave her two weeks before yielding this time.

She stayed on the bed for a while, looking at the ceiling and daydreaming about the last hour. Over time, her love for the blonde had grown so strong it almost frightened her. After all, Catra didn't know whether her lover shared her feelings. Her declaration of love was never met with the same in response, but maybe that was for the best. Pushing her thoughts away, she wondered where Adora had learned this new – and especially effective – intimate technique. Anyway, she would have two weeks to find something new to surprise her.

After a few minutes lost in thought, Catra finally stood up and made her way lazily to the bathroom. Turning on the shower, she slipped under the water and enjoyed the warm sensation. She hummed softly as she washed her hair. Then she got dressed,

looking around the room for her clothes. They hadn't taken very much care in their haste. When she left the room, the bloom on her face still hadn't faded.

At the reception, she wasn't surprised to find out Adora had already paid for the room. The blonde always wanted to do things right and that didn't change. Catra asked the receptionist if the hotel had rooms with a king size bed and took note of the answer for next time.

It was one of the three hotels they used regularly, but it remained the most useful, located just outside the town. In principle, they changed almost each time and, of course, preferred discreet places. There were a few convenient hotels downtown, close to their works, but they avoided them. Catra thought it was a little overcautious sometimes, but that seemed to be the price of Adora's peace of mind.

In the parking lot, there was already a thick layer of snow. Even after four years here, she wasn't fully accustomed to the long winters and cold temperatures. However, she had to admit the area suited her. The scenery in the middle of mountains and the peaceful atmosphere of the city were undeniable assets.

Besides the snow, the road was fairly clear, as snowplows were already making their way through the town. Before heading home, she stopped at a store to buy some groceries. Glimmer had her hands full at work at the moment, so this seemed like the perfect night to surprise her with her favorite meal.

In December, traffic started to increase due to tourists. As the area had many ski resorts, the Christmas period was always busy. Crowds bothered Catra, so she tried to avoid the packed restaurants and overcrowded stores in town for a few weeks.

She and her wife lived in a modern three-story building on the edge of the city. The neighborhood was nice, with scattered, low buildings near the forest. As she left her car in their underground

parking lot, she grabbed her shopping and gym bag from the back seat.

When she entered the apartment, the lights were already on. The place had a large living room and an open kitchen, with a wooden table and a comfy couch. In the back, there were two rooms for their bedroom and an office. The decor was clearly excessive, with lots of colorful, fluffy furniture, but she had long since given up on changing her wife's bad taste.

She was sitting at the table, focused on her laptop. Glimmer had short purple hair and a tan complexion. She was the same height as Catra and looked to be of Asian origin. She was wearing a green sweater and blue jeans.

Catra dropped her gym bag at the entrance and walked over to the table. Her wife quickly closed a window on her screen as she arrived. It was rare for Glimmer to be there so early. She usually had a lot of work at this time – and the rest of the year too, if she was honest.

Wrapping an arm around her from behind and giving her a peck on the neck, Catra said in a teasing voice, "Hon, you don't have to hide your smut from me."

"Oh, come on! I never look at these things… without you," Glimmer said, turning her head to kiss Catra's cheek.

"I hope not."

“You went shopping, didn’t you?” Glimmer asked, raising a perplexed eyebrow.

Catra walked to the kitchen, set her shopping bag on the counter, and began to put the groceries in the fridge. “Yes, I bought tomatoes. I was thinking about making pasta.”

“It’s my turn to cook.”

“Don’t complain, I know you love my sauce.”

“I don’t disagree with you on that,” Glimmer flashed her wife a smile. “How was your day?”

“I’m tired of running to the gym after work and looking forward to spring. Otherwise, the project is going well. The team finally started to connect the control panels. Normally, the first transformer should be delivered in one month.”

Taking some spices from the top cabinet, Catra avoided turning to look at Glimmer. Her day had been great, particularly the late afternoon. She felt a weight in her chest, as it happened to her sometimes during this kind of discussion. After all, she wasn’t lying – just hiding some details. She had gone to the gym on her lunch break, so it wasn’t a total lie, was it?

“You know I understand absolutely none of your engineering mumbo-jumbo,” the purple-haired woman commented, interrupting Catra’s thoughts.

“Sure, but it makes me look so passionate and sexy, doesn't it?” Catra chuckled with a wry smile.

“You’re insufferable sometimes.”

“Yet you love it so much.”

Her wife was so easy to annoy. Even after eight years of being together, Catra never tired of teasing her. They bantered for a while, as Catra cut up the tomatoes and began to cook. Catra valued this quality time deeply. They looked like insignificant moments in everyday life, but they were essential to her. The familiar atmosphere made her feel like she belonged.

Leaning against the worktop while the pasta was cooking, Catra listened to her wife talk about her day. This was a particularly stressful time for her, and Catra knew she needed a listening ear at times.

“The department heads have really over-inflated egos. I'm just tired of seeing them all the time,” Glimmer complained, resting

her head on her hand.

“It sounds tough to be the boss, hon,” Catra huffed in a sarcastic voice, flashing a smirk. She was a good listener for her wife, but she had her limits. “You make a bunch of money just for yelling at people. It really brings tears to my eyes.”

“It’s okay, sweetie. I get your point.”

“No, no, I mean it. You manage this huge, flourishing company on your own. Not to mention you’ve a smart, beautiful, and funny woman in your bed every night.”

“You’re forgetting modest,” the purple-haired woman said, rolling her eyes.

“I know, that is my greatest quality,” Catra chuckled.

“Oh, shut up!”

Glimmer tried to pout, but she couldn’t hide a smile. She had taken over her parents’ business when they retired four years earlier. This was the main reason why they had moved to the region. It had been difficult at first, but Glimmer had adapted to the role quickly. Beneath her ironic attitude, Catra was very proud of her wife's achievements. However, she needed to help her to keep her feet on the ground, when she forgot her own luck.

“I want to talk about something,” Glimmer said in a hesitant voice after a short silence

“What is it?” Catra asked in an intrigued voice, cocking her head.

Opening a window on her screen, her wife pointed to her laptop, “I was looking at the adoption process.”

“Oh.”

They were clearly leaving the banter behind them. Catra sat down next to her wife at the table. This wasn’t the first time they had

broached the subject over the years, but it had been coming up more often recently. Glimmer seemed to be thinking about it more and more. After an eight-year relationship and in their late-thirties, Catra realised this was a legitimate option.

“Sorry, I don’t mean to press you about it,” Glimmer said a little awkwardly, giving Catra an apologetic look.

Catra took her wife’s hand tenderly, “You never press me, Glim.”

“Again, I know you’re not comfortable with it.”

“No, it’s not that. I’m just not…”

Even though they had talked about it a few times, Catra still had trouble explaining her true feelings. It wasn't that she didn’t want to start a family with Glimmer, but she was a wreck. She barely felt like a functional person some days and wondered what she had to give. After all, what did she know about parenthood? Having grown up in the foster system herself, she hadn’t seen many good examples. Lost in her own thoughts, she didn’t know where to start.

“Hey, I know,” Glimmer said simply, intertwining her fingers with hers. “I’ve already told you, you’d be a fantastic parent.“

This reassuring hand made Catra feel grounded. She was pulled away from her negative thoughts and huffed, “You give me too much credit sometimes, hon.”

“I don’t think so. Someone has to give you what you deserve,” her wife said, tenderly kissing the back of Catra’s.

Glimmer’s hazel eyes were so full of softness Catra felt a lump in her throat. In moments like this, she didn’t know why such a wonderful woman was with her. Maybe she had done something really good in a past life, or it was fate, or she was just incredibly fortunate. Whatever it was, her wife had been the first person to try to genuinely know or understand her.

“Stop being so sappy,” Catra replied in a cracked voice, looking away. “Listen, let’s have our dinner. Then we’ll look at what you’ve found.”

“That sounds perfect to me,” Glimmer agreed, without looking away.

“I’ll have a think about it. I’m not promising anything.”

“That’s all I’m asking.”

Her wife leaned forward and gave her a quick kiss on her cheek. They shared a knowing look as Catra stood up to finish preparing dinner.

We Are Still Friends

Even though she couldn’t admit it and pretended it was only a commercial event, Catra enjoyed the Christmas season. First, she had time off between Christmas and New Year. Those few days of rest allowed her a change from everyday life. As her wife’s business was also closed during this time, they were able to spend a lot of it together. It was one of the rare occasions when her wife seemed to really take time out from her work.

For a few days, they had lots of opportunities to spend time together. They enjoyed cross-country skiing at the different resorts in the area. Despite the abundance of tourists, they felt alone on the trail in the middle of the forest. At other times, they simply cuddled up on their couch drinking hot chocolate. Those were precious moments for both of them.

However, they weren't always alone throughout the break. Her wife’s parents organized a Christmas Eve dinner and other informal family gatherings. It was always an excellent opportunity to see the whole family and to spend an enjoyable evening, usually washed down with a few glasses of fine wine.

Years earlier, Catra’s in-laws had welcomed her warmly into the family the second Glimmer had introduced her, and that hadn’t changed. To her surprise, Catra really got along with her wife’s parents. Micah, her father-in-law, was always considerate, and Angella, her mother-in-law, had a good heart under her stern exterior.

Over the years, her in-laws had become her own family. Growing up in the foster system, Catra had never stayed in the same place for long. So she hadn’t really known what having a family was like until meeting her wife.

For that reason, Catra really enjoyed the festive season. However, on the last day of the year, Catra felt a pinch in her chest as she parked her car in front of an overly decorated house. There were

too many garlands on the facade and a chubby Santa sitting in his sleigh by the front door.

Adora and Bow had invited them and some other friends for New Year's Eve. Their house was in a quiet quarter on the periphery of the town.

"Oh gosh, it's getting worse and worse every year," Catra commented as she looked at the flashy house.

"You know Bow. He has no sense of moderation with decorating," Glimmer said, shrugging with a faint smile.

"You're not in position to talk about it."

"Hey!"

Catra didn't answer and got out of the car, flashing a smile at her wife. Glimmer had decorated their living room with a bunch of kitschy tinsel and an overly-bright Christmas tree. Giving her wife an arm to help her walk on the frozen ground in her heels, they headed for the front door, still joking about the lights.

Under her maroon coat, Glimmer wore an elegant purple dress to match her hair. Catra had chosen a dark purple suit decorated with a pink border, which she wore for special occasions, and the long burgundy coat which her wife adored, calling it her "sexy coat". As soon as they rang the doorbell, Adora opened the door with a broad smile and greeted them warmly.

She wore a sleeveless red dress, showing off her toned shoulders and athletic arms. Catra felt her throat go dry when she looked at the blonde. She couldn't help staring at the bare curve of her shoulders. After only two weeks, she hadn't realized how much she was missing her.

"I can't believe it's been almost two months! I'm so happy to see you both," Adora said in a friendly voice, looking at Glimmer, but avoiding Catra's eyes.

“I know, but I haven’t had much time to myself recently,” Glimmer apologized, taking off her coat.

“You promised we’d go back to the gym in January, didn't you?”

“Of course, I won't-”

Her sentence was interrupted by the yelling of children. A horde of kids ran down the hall without stopping their games. In an instant, they were gone, as quickly as they had arrived. In the group were Adora’s son and daughter and the two kids of their friends, Mermista and Hawk.

Bow followed the noisy party to greet them with a friendly smile. He was tall, with a dark complexion, and short, dark hair. His eyes brightened with joy and kindness. He was wearing a navy-blue polo shirt and light-colored pants.

"You always come last," he said, opening his arms to hug Glimmer.

"We've a reputation to maintain," Glimmer laughed, wrapping him in her arms.

He was her wife’s oldest friend. They had known each other since elementary school and remained close over the years. Catra glanced at the blonde, but Adora seemed to look everywhere except at her.

At the end of their embrace, he turned to Catra and tapped her on the shoulder, "I hope you haven’t let up on your training. There will be a lot of runs next year."

Catra snorted wryly, "Don't worry about me, little guy."

"Come on, everyone is waiting for you," he said, waving his hand and walking into the living room.

After putting their coats on the rack, they followed him. Catra knew the place well; they often visited their friends. There was a

comfy living room, three bedrooms, and a large backyard. The couple's children were six and eight years old and had plenty of room to play. The house wasn't huge, but it was enough for a family of four. As there was outside, there were too many Christmas decorations and loud conversation came from the living room.

Catra stopped in the doorway, then turned to look at Adora. The blonde was left alone in the hallway, absentmindedly arranging the coats.

"Are you coming?" Catra asked, raising an intrigued eyebrow.

"I'll be there in a minute," Adora replied without turning her head.

Catra couldn’t hide her smile, "Sure. Nice dress, by the way."

"Thanks, your suit is nice too."

"I haven't worn it since the lake. Of course, you didn't let me wear it long that day, did you?"

In the summer, they had spent one sunny day and a particularly sensual night at a hotel near a lake an hour away. They had both used a business trip to excuse their absence. Their trip was still vivid in Catra's memory. They had wandered along the lake shore holding hands. The place offered a splendid landscape, but Adora was even more beautiful to admire at sunset. At the dinner, she had worn the suit and Adora had loved it. It had been one of their few entire nights together.

Finally looking at her with wide eyes, Adora whispered, upset, "Stop it, right now."

"Don't worry, I'm kidding. This is not the place," Catra said, looking around to make sure they were alone.

"There’s no place for it anymore."

"If you say so, princess."

Clearly, it wasn't the place with their partners in the other room, but Catra couldn't help teasing her. The blonde looked so radiant in her dress with her hair falling over her shoulders. Adora didn't answer but couldn't hide a slight smile. She passed Catra, brushing their shoulders purposely, and entered the living room.

The smile haunted Catra well into the night. Sure, she was happy to listen to her ever-overenthusiastic friend Scorpia. The generous caramelized duck, which Bow had spent half the day cooking, was as usual delicious. The inevitable bickering between Mermista and her husband was as funny as ever. Yet nothing could be compared to that simple half-smile.

After the meal, the discussion carried on in a relaxed atmosphere. While they settled into the comfy sofas for the evening, Catra took refuge alone in the kitchen. Dinner had already taken its toll on her social skills and she needed a short break. Enjoying the calm, she leaned against the counter and sipped her wine.

Her wife entered a few minutes later, giving her a smile, “You’re hiding, aren’t you?”

“You know me. I’m good at playing hard to get,” Catra chuckled, as her wife settled next to her.

“Sure you are,” her wife said, bumping her gently with her shoulder. “But are you okay? You've got to catch your breath.”

“I’ve had a slight overdose of socializing, but I’ll be back in a minute.”

“Take your time, my grumpy loner,” the purple-haired woman teased, giving Catra a peck on the cheek.

With a slight smile, Catra watched her wife leave the room. The first time they had met, she hadn’t been able to put up with her posh attitude and stubborn temper. Catra had seen her as a spoiled brat. However, beneath her armor, Glimmer had quickly revealed herself to be a genuinely caring and generous person.

Just as she was ready to leave her retreat, Catra heard cries from the living room. A few seconds later, Adora entered the kitchen, holding her daughter by her hands. The child was crying and the blonde sat her down on a chair. She had fallen while playing with the others, but it was obviously nothing serious. At nearly 11 pm, the six-year-old was just tired.

Adora crouched in front of the chair and began to comfort her. The little girl's tears gradually stopped as her mother rubbed her arms and whispered soothing words. Catra was almost hypnotized by the scene. The blonde looked so naturally maternal she felt a twinge in her chest. She wondered if she would ever be that good at it.

A minute later, the child seemed to have forgotten her tears. She rushed out of the room as if nothing had happened. Catra was still staring, eyes filled with awe, when Adora stood up and looked at her. The blonde frowned and walked over to Catra.

Adora glanced at the door and whispered, "Stop looking at me with those eyes!"

Catra was a little taken aback, but quickly shook herself, "Sorry princess, I'll borrow different ones next time."

The blonde crossed her arms over her chest, giving her an annoyed look.

Catra was ready to make fun of the blonde again, but she changed her mind and asked in a hesitant voice, "How do you get so skilled with children? It seems so easy for you."

It was Adora's turn to look a bit taken aback by the change of topic, "What do you mean?"

"Glimmer and I are talking about adoption."

The blonde nodded slowly, and her face softened immediately. She uncrossed her arms and leaned against the countertop. Adora was her lover, of course, but she had been her friend first. Except

Scorpia, who she had known in college, the blonde had been Catra's first friend when she had moved to the area four years earlier. When they had slipped under the sheets, it hadn’t changed their friendship. Pretty much the opposite had happened; a new layer of feeling had grown between them. They still shared their secrets, doubts, and fears.

“And that’s what you want?” Adora asked in a caring voice.

“I want to build something with Glimmer, but you know…” Catra replied, shrugging with a fuzzy smile. “When I see you with your kids, I’m not sure I can do that.”

“When we adopted Fynn, I was totally lost at first. I was always afraid of making mistakes or messing up. And you know, I probably did, a lot.”

“Great, you’re a ray of sunshine,” Catra huffed ironically, pinching the bridge of her nose.

“But gradually, I thought less and less about it. After all, it couldn’t be worse than how I grew up,” Adora continued, casually placing her hand on Catra’s and giving her a knowing look.

She and Adora had a similar childhood in many ways. Both had endured the foster system and had grown up with constant instability. This was strangely one of the points that had driven them together when they met. They understood each other on many levels. However, there was one thing Catra didn’t understand; how could the blonde be so balanced, loving and confident, when she felt such a mess herself?

“I get it,” Catra said thoughtfully, looking at her out of the corner of her eye. “Glim thinks I'd be a good parent.”

“She’s right,” Adora agreed, nodding slowly. “But-”

“But?”

“There isn't only one way to build something. Your choice should suit you both,” the blonde replied, briefly squeezing Catra’s hand.

They shared a gentle look, then Adora stood up sharply and withdrew her hand. She glanced uncertainly between the closed door and Catra. At that moment, Catra wanted to move forward and feel her lips against hers. She was starving for the taste of her neck, for the softness of her skin. Of course, it was a foolish idea.

“I think we should join the others, don’t you?” Adora stammered, adjusting her dress.

“Yeah, we should. Thanks for listening to me, princess.”

Without answering, but with a knowing smile, Adora walked towards the door. Catra got up and followed her to the living room. There was still a lot to think about with the possibility of a family, but that could wait. For tonight, she just wanted to enjoy herself and have another drink.

Keeping Up Good Resolutions

At the beginning of the year, fresh snow covered the mountains and forests in the area. The town regained its quiet atmosphere once the tourists had finished their winter breaks. Early January was also a time to make resolutions. The change of year seemed to be the perfect time to make a fresh start. It could be starting a healthy diet, getting back into exercise, or stopping an extramarital relationship. There really was something for everybody.

As happened every January, the gym was packed. After a few minutes, Adora had found a free treadmill in the corner. The crowd didn't bother her; she knew it wouldn't last long. In a few weeks, the gym would be half empty again. However, there was something which had been haunting her mind for the past week or so. The thought caught her as soon as she woke up. It followed her all day. It chased her even to her bed. Especially to her bed.

This invasive idea had intense mismatched eyes, soft caramel skin, and a wildflower smell. But this wasn't the problem, absolutely not. She had made her decision and wouldn't change her mind. Pressing the control screen, Adora increased the speed of the treadmill. As she sped up, her breaths became shorter, and her legs began to ache. It was perfect; she could push away those unwanted dreams from her head.

"Wow, calm down Adora. You're going to pass out," Glimmer said beside her.

Reducing her speed, Adora turned her head to look at Glimmer who was running slowly on the treadmill next to her. "Don't worry, I'm not the one who stopped training for months," She commented, catching her breath.

The purple-haired woman rolled her eyes, "That's a low blow. I'm not out of shape; I just need to find my feet."

“Sure, you do.”

Finally, Glimmer had found the time to return to the gym with her. They usually went once a week, but the purple-haired woman hadn't been in two months. Her job seemed to give her more free time with the new year. Adora was genuinely pleased to be spending time with her best friend again, but she also felt a little awkward. In the back of her mind, there was always a mix of guilt, jealousy, and embarrassment. Of course, this was nothing new, but she would never get used to it.

"Are you okay? You seemed a bit out of touch today," Glimmer asked, grabbing her flask and taking a sip.

Adora clearly was. However, 'I can't stop thinking about your wife's lips' didn't seem like the right response, so she said, "The kids are always a bit difficult at the end of vacations."

"I can imagine. It's a change for them."

"Yes, but they’ll quickly get used to being back at school. In a few days, they'll be fine. What about you, is everything okay?"

"Yeah, I talk to Catra a lot about family," Glimmer said, stopping her machine and stepping down.

When she stopped her own treadmill, Adora got off and grabbed her towel. She knew this was a sensitive topic for her two friends and her discussion with Catra on New Year’s Eve had shown it. The brunette seemed to have been struggling with this question for a long time. Adora understood the fear and doubt all too well, as she had experienced it.

She and Catra were friends, but they were, or rather had been, more than that. Adora wanted to help her, but at the same time it wasn't her place to do so. There were boundaries. She often wondered what space they really had for each other. After all, she and Catra had their own partners, their own families, and their own life.

"Has anything come of your talking?" Adora asked, wiping her forehead with the towel.

"Yeah. We're going to start a procedure to become a foster family," Glimmer said, taking her towel from the machine.

"Really, I didn't think you'd consider that."

"We weren't, but Catra suggested it."

Adora was somewhat surprised by this information. Glimmer had been talking about starting a family for years, but this idea had never come up in this way. They headed towards a couple of free exercise bikes as Glimmer clarified their plan. The couple wanted to become a foster family for a pre-teen or teenager. It was typically the age where you got stuck in the foster system, and Adora knew this all too well.

"It's not an easy option, that age," Adora commented, staring at her pensively.

"To be honest, I was thinking about adopting young children, like you and Bow," the purple-haired one said, nodding slowly as they got on the bikes. "But I think it's Catra's way of giving the help she never had."

"I can't blame her," and Adora really couldn't. "But are you okay with it?"

"To my surprise, yes, I'm okay with that. It's not what I expected, but it seems strangely right. There is no one way to form a family, is there?"

Shaking her head, Adora said, "Of course not."

As she began to pedal, they continued to talk about this. Glimmer's wife seemed reassured by the temporary aspect of being a foster family. However, Glimmer hadn't forgotten her adoption idea, she just knew Catra needed to take baby steps.

After all, a temporary placement could turn into something much more permanent. Who knew?

Adora couldn't hide a smile at her friend's enthusiasm. She had spent enough time in foster families to appreciate the sincerity of their approach. They weren't looking for a paycheck. It wasn't an act of pity or based on savior complex. Catra had known what it was like firsthand. Adora knew they would certainly be good parents.

There was one point which bothered her, "Don't take offense, but children totally change your life. Are you ready for that? I mean, your business takes up a lot of your time."

After a few seconds of silence, Glimmer replied, "I'm going to take a step back from it."

"Can you do that?"

"I've got some ideas. I'm the boss, so I can find a way," the purple-haired one said with a smug smile. "I haven't been around enough for Catra this year, so it will be good for us."

Her two friends had time-consuming jobs; that was nothing new. Glimmer had taken over her parents' business and Catra was usually busy with her engineering. Glimmer explained that the couple were planning to reduce their working hours up until the summer, before becoming foster parents.

At the beginning of their affair, Adora had imagined they had grown closer because Catra was lonely or had some problem in her relationship. However, she had never seen any signs of this. Glimmer and Catra had their ups and downs like everyone else, but they were always so balanced. The brunette had never complained about her wife – quite the opposite.

"That's great for both of you, really great," Adora commented, honestly happy for her friends.

“Thanks, but it’s also partly because of you she took the plunge,” Glimmer said with a wry smile.

“What?”

“I know you talked about it. Your opinion means a lot to her, and she admires the way you are with your children.”

Adora rubbed the back of her neck, “I don’t think she admires me.”

“Of course she does. She won’t admit it, but I think it’s true.”

The words were flattering, but no one admired her. Adora knew people found her reliable, honest, and organized. These were good qualities, respectable ones, but certainly not admirable in her eyes. That someone so smart, so beautiful, and so funny could admire her was clearly irrelevant. Half of the time, she wondered why the brunette was taking so many risks to spend such brief moments with her.

Catra had said several times she loved her, but that was probably just sweet talk or a lover’s spiel. Yet, two years after their first night, they were still meeting. Well, no, they weren’t, because Adora had stopped it. It was the right thing to do. She remained convinced. Fully, totally, and indubitably convinced.

By the end of their workout, Adora was deep in thought. They continued to talk, but she answered absent-mindedly. She slipped onto autopilot, as her mind couldn’t pull away from the memory of mismatched eyes. She thought of nothing else while she showered, changed, and packed her sports clothes. As they walked out of the gym, even the cold didn’t wake her from her daydream.

“We’ll meet again at the same time next week, right?” Glimmer asked, as she tightened her coat around her to keep warm.

“Yeah, if you are still able to move,” Adora joked distractedly.

“Hey, I’m not that out of shape,” the purple-haired one retorted, as she turned and walked away along the sidewalk.

“We’ll see.”

Glimmer waved her hand over her head, “See you soon. Thanks for the workout.”

Adjusting her gym bag on her shoulder, Adora slowly made her way to her car which was parked across the street.

She dropped her bag on the back seat, then got in, letting out a deep sigh. The interior was as cold as the exterior, but at least there was no wind. She grabbed her phone from her coat pocket and gazed at the black screen without moving.

She knew this was a terrible idea. After all, she had made her decision, and it was the right thing to do. There was nothing fair about this situation. She betrayed Bow, jeopardized her family, and betrayed her best friend. More than once, Adora had hated herself for putting them in this situation. Everyone had too much to lose, and for what?

Adora had absolutely nothing to gain from their brief, hazardous meetings. Of course, she never felt more alive than when Catra’s arms were wrapped around her. Adora was starved to touch her, to smell her and to taste her. However, it wasn’t only physical. It was always so natural to talk to Catra about everything. It felt like she had known her all her life. But that didn’t make up for everything else.

Definitively, her resolution to end the relationship remained the only reasonable choice. But she unlocked her phone and wrote a message, ‘I’m sorry about last time. I miss you. Can we meet?’ She hesitated for a few long seconds, before sending the text with a trembling thumb.

The brunette’s answer came less than a minute later and was just two words: ‘King-size?’

Reading the text, she rolled her eyes, but couldn’t hold back a smile, ‘Yes, I’ll find a room. Can you do next Tuesday or Wednesday?’

‘Tuesday’s perfect! I missed you too, princess.’

As she put her phone down on the passenger seat, she felt light and wore a dreamy smile. It was certainly not the ideal situation, but she had to deal with that. After all, what could go wrong? She could think of nothing but Catra's eyes as she started the car and drove away.

Posh People Are All the Same

Four years earlier

The day was particularly warm for an early spring Sunday. Winter coats had been replaced by light jackets and the birds were singing again. The last few weeks had been sunny and the forest was already bright with shades of green. The snow-capped mountains and the forest formed a striking contrast. The smell of the spring filled the air.

Slumping in the passenger seat, Catra watched the landscape through the side window. She had moved here only a month earlier, but she could already tell she didn't like this dump. The area seemed to have nothing but forests, mountains, and rivers. Catra had lived in a south coast city all her life, so her expectations for nature consisted mostly of beaches and the sea. Besides, she disliked the cold.

Well, there were some pleasant things too. Her new job at the local utility company didn't seem too bad. There were even one or two colleagues who weren't totally annoying. She sometimes wondered why she had moved at all. To be honest, her wife was the only reason, but that was enough. With her parents' retirement, her partner was taking over the family company. It was a big change for them, but it was important for Glimmer.

"You'll see, they always make these delicious meals," the purple-haired woman said, while she drove the car.

"Sure, mister and misses perfect are excellent cooks, of course," Catra replied sarcastically, glancing at her wife.

"Please, don't call them that. They're my best friends, and you have only met them twice."

"Twice is enough with these posh folks," Catra chuckled and smiled wryly. "At our wedding, they looked at me like I wasn't

good enough for you.”

"They're not like that. You should give them a chance."

"You know we don't need to have the same friends."

"We wouldn't be together if we didn’t share a friend," Glimmer gave her a knowing look.

Indeed, their friend Scorpia had introduced them. She had set them up on a date when Glimmer had just moved to Bright City. With the excuse of helping Glimmer fit into her new place, Scorpia had pestered Catra for several weeks. Even though they lived a thousand kilometers away, her friend had still texted and called about it every day. Catra had finally given in and agreed to the stupid date. She had been upset at the time, but she could tell that the result wouldn’t bother her. Just three years later, they were married, and she couldn’t remember being so happy.

"It's not my fault. Scorpia trapped me on the first day of college and I’ve never managed to get rid of her since," Catra said, waving her hand.

The purple-haired one rolled her eyes, "Okay, but can you try to be nice to them for just a few hours?"

Catra looked at her blankly, raising a puzzled eyebrow.

"Or at least not to be rude?"

"Seriously, do you know your wife at all? I'll be all sweetness and light with your dear Anna and Burt."

Glimmer groaned, glancing at her wife, "Whatever, do what you want."

A few minutes later, they parked in front of a large house in the town’s upscale suburbs. There was a lot of green space around the house and she could see a nice backyard behind it. Looking around the place, Catra wasn’t really surprised to see that her

wife's friends lived there. It seemed to be the ideal neighborhood for their kind of snob.

As soon as they got out of the car, Bow and his son Fynn walked out of the house to welcome them. Adora greeted them in the doorway, holding their little daughter Maia in her arms. Despite her words, Catra knew they were her wife's best friends, so she avoided her usual sarcasm.

However, a quick tour of the house reinforced her impression with their sophisticated decor and stylish furniture. They were the cliché of the preppy couple, with their perfect family in their fancy house. Catra felt like they weren't from the same world. Admittedly, her own wife came from a fairly well-to-do family, but sleeping with her made her less critical on this point.

As they settled down at a table in the garden for a pre-lunch drink, Catra's opinions of them were solidified. Bow was far too helpful and talkative, and it was too much to be honest. Adora seemed to need every detail to be perfect and was an overly attentive host, which made her seem unnatural and particularly annoying. As for their kids, well, they seemed pretty great, and it wasn't their fault if their parents were stuck-up upper middle class.

As the weather was nice, their hosts set out the meal in the garden. Her wife had been right, the fresh pasta was excellent, a touch spicy and with a hint of rosemary. Of course, it wasn't as tasty as her own recipes, but Catra had to admit Bow was pretty good in the kitchen. Besides, the red wine went well with the food, so she didn't deprive herself of an extra glass. However, she contributed little to the conversation, leaving her wife to enjoy the reunion with her old friends.

After lunch, the children played on the lawn with their parents and Glimmer, allowing Catra to enjoy some quiet time at the table. Unfortunately, her peace was interrupted when Adora settled down opposite her. Groaning inwardly, Catra thought it was

probably in some kind of posh hosting manual to not leave a guest alone.

“What do you think of the town?” The blonde asked in a friendly voice, lifting her wine glass from the table.

Catra held back a sigh; she was in no mood to make small talk with this goose. However, the blonde was Glimmer’s friend, after all, and the third glass of wine was helping too, “I’m not used to being surrounded by the mountains. It’s a big change from Bright City.”

“Yeah, I bet our small town doesn't have the same atmosphere. I also needed some time to find my feet when we moved here.”

Catra simply nodded, hoping to end the discussion. But the blonde looked at her quietly, seemingly hoping for more. She definitely couldn’t avoid this boring chit chat session. “You seem to be fitting in well now. It’s a nice house,” Catra commented casually.

“Thanks, the neighborhood is nice, but we’ll probably be in debt for the rest of our lives. We moved in six months ago when we had Maia.”

Catra raised a puzzled eyebrow. She glanced at the kid, who ran around the garden – obviously older than six months.

“We adopted her and Fynn,” Adora explained, seeming to notice Catra’s questioning look. Then she added in a thoughtful voice, “They still need to find their place as siblings, but it’s better than a group home.”

A preppy blonde with a huge savior complex – Catra’s favorite type of person. In just two minutes, her host had already rambled about her personal life, so generously. She had an ego the size of the surrounding mountains. However, she couldn’t deny the last part, this cozy house with parents looked much better than the other possibility.

“Yes, it is. I can attest to that firsthand,” Catra said in a deadpan voice, sipping at her drink.

“Seriously?” The blonde asked, turning a surprised face towards her.

Catra wondered what kind of question this was. Who wouldn’t be serious about that? She was fed up with this snooty goose, and replied rudely, “Yes, princess. Not every kid gets a fancy house.”

Raising a calming hand, Adora said awkwardly, “No, I meant I spent years in the system. I was surprised you went through that too. It’s not common.”

Catra frowned, a little taken aback. This was unexpected to say the least. She and Miss Goody-Goody had something like that in common. The blonde was perhaps a little less preppy than she had expected. At that moment, her blue eyes seemed more sincere, and her perfect ponytail less haughty.

Catra leaned back against her seat, “I probably toured every group home and foster family on the south coast until I came of age.”

“I grew up further north, but it was a pretty similar experience,” Adora shrugged and tucked a strand of hair behind her ear.

“You mean shitty.”

“I think we can summarize it like this,” the blonde said, fiddling with the edge of the table. “I’m just relieved that my children don't have to live with that kind of instability.”

Turning her drink in her hand, Catra remained quiet for a moment, then commented, “I get it. I can’t remember the faces of half of the people I lived with over the years.”

“After a while, I didn’t bother learning the names of other kids or the caretakers.”

“Why learn names when they probably wouldn’t be around the next day?”

After these words, they shared a knowing look. Then they fell into a pensive, but not awkward, silence.

Catra was definitely tipsy; she almost never talked about her childhood. Over the years, she had discussed it with Glimmer, of course, and her wife was always a good listener. She had also been in therapy where she had spoken about her past. Catra had been fortunate to find people to help and understand her. However, the blonde didn’t just understand; she knew. It was one of the first times she could share this without having to explain herself.

“Sorry to cast a cloud over the day, I didn’t expect to bring back this kind of memory,” Adora apologized after a while, rubbing the back of her neck.

“Don’t worry, it's ancient history,” Catra said in a reassuring voice, giving her a slight smile.

“Yeah, but it’s not the most pleasant subject,” the blonde stammered, clearing her throat and seeming to look for another topic. “Glimmer told me you’ve already found a job in town.”

“I was hired before we moved. It’s on regional utilities, mostly on the power grid projects.”

“That sounds interesting, although I don’t really get what it’s about. Your building is next to the train station, isn't it?”

”Don’t worry, Glim doesn't get it either, even after four years. But our office is next to the station, yeah,” Catra chuckled with an amused smile. “How about you? You work at the hospital, don’t you?”

“Yes, I’m at the central pharmacy.”

They talked casually about their respective jobs, before moving on to local gossip. Sure, Adora rambled for most of it, but Catra surprisingly didn't find the conversation boring. The blonde was pretty funny in her own way, even when it wasn't necessarily intentional.

After a while, Glimmer and Bow joined them at the table, and the conversation continued to flow nicely.

As Adora recommended new restaurants in town, she told Catra, "If you've time, we could take our lunch break together sometime."

"It would be good, because she can be a real hermit," Glimmer commented, flashing a wry smile at Catra.

"Hey, I'm not! I'm just selective," Catra protested, nudging her wife. "But why not? That would be nice."

Even though her wife was joking, she wasn't entirely wrong. That would be really nice; Catra didn't know many people here. For once, maybe she and Glimmer could share some friends.

Five Minutes Before the Apocalypse

The weather on Sunday was cloudy, but dry and mild. It was early spring. Catra felt great on this forest path. The ground was still a bit muddy after the rain of the last few days, but that didn't bother her. The pine trees were just beginning to regain their color, and a few birds were already singing here and there. She loved the quiet atmosphere. Her working days were usually split between her office and construction sites, so the forest was always a welcome change.

After the long winter of the region, she could exercise outside. She missed her Sunday morning runs. Even though the gym was an alternative throughout the winter, it wasn't the same. Running had always been a special time for her, when she could be alone with herself and recharge. Before living here, she had never been particularly attracted to forests and mountains, to say the least. However, the landscape had grown on her as she had explored the area over the past four years.

Even though she wouldn’t admit it, she loved living here. For the first time in her life, she felt she had a real home. Since the beginning of the year, things seemed to move more quickly. She and her wife had prepared their application, and their lives, to become a foster family. They had already met with a social worker, and everything seemed on the right track. According to their plan, they would reduce their working hours slowly until the summer.

Her wife had talked about adoption for a while, so Catra had been a little uncomfortable bringing up the idea of a foster family. She knew it wasn’t exactly how her wife imagined starting a family. Glimmer had always talked about adopting young children; not being a foster family for older ones. Catra was a bit worried she would just see it as a fallback solution. Much to her surprise, her wife was particularly open to the idea. It was a way for them of giving what she hadn't received growing up.

Looking at her watch, Catra was quite satisfied with her training. Her muscles were slightly sore, but she felt soothed. In her enthusiasm to be outside again, she had pushed her limits and she loved the feeling. When she came out of the forest, her place was only a few hundred meters away. She walked the last part slowly to catch her breath.

Entering the apartment, the atmosphere was silent. Her wife was sitting at the kitchen table, deep in thought. She had light dark rings under her eyes and her short purple hair was messy. She was wearing flashy red pajamas with music notes patterns; she looked like she just rolled out of bed. There was a cup of coffee in front of her, but she hadn't started it.

Catra greeted her in a lively voice, as she had left for her jog before her wife woke up. However, the purple-haired woman didn’t move, eyes fixed on the table thoughtfully.

“Glim,” Catra called a second time to catch her attention.

Glimmer looked up in surprise, as though pulled from a dream, finally spotting her wife, “Oh, hi, I didn’t hear you come in.”

Catra walked over to the sink and poured herself a glass of water. “I got it, hon. You seemed far away,” she commented playfully, flashing a smile.

“I was just thinking,” her wife said in a weary voice, fidgeting with her coffee cup.

“Can I help?”

Her wife had looked tired for a few weeks. With their family project, she had a lot to reorganize in her company before the summer. She had been spending long hours at her office, so they hadn’t seen each other much through the week.

“I’m not sure,” Glimmer huffed, then gazed at Catra for a few long seconds. “Well, maybe.”

“Whatever you need,” Catra said in a supportive voice, sipping her water and sitting down at the table.

Glimmer stood up, raising her hand to ask Catra to wait a second, and went into their bedroom. She returned with a piece of paper and placed it on the table, then sat back down. "Can you help me with this?" She asked, looking at her wife intently.

Catra raised a perplexed eyebrow and grabbed the paper. "What is this? Is it for the social-" she stopped mid-sentence, as she scanned the document.

"Do you know what this is? I found it in the car."

Glancing at Glimmer, Catra felt her throat go dry. The note was a hotel bill from last month. It was clearly from a meeting with Adora. There was no name, but the last few numbers of her credit card left no doubt. She had probably forgotten it, or lost it in the car, and she wondered how she could have been so reckless. Whatever, it was awkward, but not catastrophic. After all, there were hundreds of possible explanations. She just had to be careful, very careful, because her wife was many things, but she was not stupid.

"I paid for a hotel for a potential client, but the company will refund me," Catra explained in the most natural voice possible.

"Oh, sure, you’re dealing with potential clients now, are you?" her wife commented coldly, frowning a little. "Where were you last week?"

"What?"

"Last week, when you went on a *business trip* ," the purple-haired woman asked, waving her hand dismissively.

"I needed to monitor device testing in a factory for my project, as you know."

Their conversation was taking a wrong turn, and Catra's stomach was tied in knots. A week earlier, she and Adora had spent a night by the lake, just like last summer. Once again, it had been magical, with a stroll along the water, a romantic dinner, and a sensual night. However, that magic seemed far away in that moment.

"Please stop lying to me!" Glimmer huffed, pinching the bridge of her nose. "I called your work and they told me you had the day off."

Running a hand through her hair, Catra said in an anxious voice, "It's not what you think."

"So what do you think I'm thinking?"

Catra opened and closed her month a few times but couldn't speak.

"Are you sleeping with someone else?" Glimmer asked after a moment, catching her wife's eyes intensely.

The question hit Catra like a punch to the gut. She tried to think of an explanation or excuse, but her mind was empty. The situation was turning into a nightmare. Her wife knew and all her answers were useless. She couldn't add more insult to injury and keep lying to her.

Taking a short breath, Catra began, "Listen, I can explain-"

"Oh, gosh, It's true!" Glimmer shouted, slamming her palm against the table, and jumping to her feet.

"I made a mistake, but-"

"A mistake! What mistake?" Glimmer said as she walked up and down the kitchen. "How did you accidentally screw someone?"

Catra stood up, trying to take her wife's hands, "Listen, I know I messed up."

Pushing Catra's hands away, Glimmer shouted as tears began to fall from her brown eyes, "Don't you dare to touch me!"

Catra stepped back, raising placating hands. When she saw her wife was crying, her heart broke. She hated herself for inflicting this on her, but she didn't know what to do. Glimmer was the most important part of her life – no, she was her whole life. Catra knew her actions had been contemptible, but she would fix it. They could fix it.

"I'm sorry. You're the only one who ever mattered. It was a mistake, but that doesn't mean anything," Catra argued, keeping some distance.

"How long have you been doing it?" Glimmer asked, stopping in place to look coldly at her wife.

"It doesn't matter. I will stop everything."

"How long?" The purple-haired woman insisted, wiping her eyes with the back of her hand.

"Two… Two years."

The truth sounded even worse out loud. Catra felt her life collapsing in front of her. She would have preferred to lie, but she couldn't. She had no strength left for that. Glimmer half-opened her mouth with a blank stare. She seemed stunned, stepping back and leaning against the countertop.

"Two years. Two years," Glimmer repeated slowly, as though she was trying to absorb information.

"Can we talk about it? I'll fix it. I can make it up to you," Catra pleaded with an imploring look.

"Talk about what? You've had two years to fix it," Glimmer yelled. "What am I to you? Our relationship is just a distraction!"

"Of course not, you're everything. I love you."

“This is why – This is why you never wanted to start a family.”

“No!” Catra said, but her wife was no longer listening.

Glimmer went through their whole history in light of this new reality. Their whole life was a lie. Catra tried to apologize, beg, and explain, but her wife had stopped listening. Her words didn’t seem to calm her down or even reach her. Helpless in the face of her wife's sadness, Catra was out of her depth. She went pale and felt her eyes fill with tears.

Glimmer was walking back and forth in the kitchen, shouting, seeing lies in every detail of their relationship. Then she stopped suddenly and asked angrily, “Who is she?”

Instinctively taking a step back, Catra shook her head. A lump in her throat kept her from answering. She couldn’t, she absolutely couldn’t open this door.

The purple-haired one looked at her with wide eyes and reached her, repeating with cold determination, “Who?”

Shaking her head again in a desperate attempt to mitigate her wife’s anger, Catra croaked “Glim, I can’t.”

“You can’t! You can’t sleep with her and not tell me her name! I deserve to know the whore you decided to ruin our lives for!”

Of course, her wife deserved to know. She deserved the world, but Catra couldn’t ruin someone else’s life. There was no way she was going to drag Adora into this mess. She was desperately looking for a way out, another solution. She never wanted this for any of them.

“It won’t help,” Catra said in a trembling voice, tears rolling down her cheeks.

“I know her, don’t I?” Glimmer asked in an almost hysterical voice, breathing rapidly and grasping Catra’s shoulders. “Who? Is it Scorpia or your colleague Entrapta? Who is it?”

“It’s Adora.”

An expression of aversion immediately appeared on her wife’s face. She pulled her hands away, as though they might be soiled. It was the first time Catra had seen such revulsion in her wife’s eyes. She didn’t dare to move, just looking at her with a desperate expression. Then, Glimmer’s face turned blank, and she rushed into their room without another word.

“Glim,” Catra called weakly, but there was no answer.

A few seconds later, Glimmer returned, wearing her brown coat over her red pajamas. Heading for the front door without a glance at Catra, she slipped on her sneakers.

“Please, Glimmer, can we talk? I’m sorry for everything. I love you.”

Looking up, her wife glared at her and said in a harsh tone, “I don’t want you to be here when I get back.”

As Glimmer stormed out without looking back, Catra slumped to the kitchen floor. Catching her head in her hands, she repeated, between sobs: “I’m sorry.”

She didn’t know exactly how long she had stayed on the floor, but it couldn’t have been more than a few minutes when the thought hit her. She knew her wife well enough to guess where she would go. Despite her jelly legs, she forced herself to stand up and staggered into their room. She grabbed her phone from the nightstand and called Adora, hoping to at least let the blonde know. In all this devastation, there was perhaps still something which could be saved.

The Hell Has Purple Hair

The sweet smell of waffles filled the whole kitchen. Adora loved the smell because it brought back so many memories. Since her first year in university, it had been part of her Sunday morning routine. First thing, the kitchen of the women's dormitory had been filled with the same scent. Now, each weekend, Bow cooked his waffles on the same wobbly hotplate.

After growing up in the foster system, the dorm had been the first place Adora felt at home. Sure, the building was old, the paint faded, and the room narrow and gloomy, but she had met some of the most important people in her life there. There was, of course, her husband, but also her closest friend Glimmer and her former roommate Perfuma. For the first time, Adora had formed a bond with them.

Bow's room had been on the same floor, just two doors down from hers. They had gotten along quickly, then their friendship turned into something else over time. They hadn't fallen in love at the first sight, but their relationship built up gradually. Both were still searching for themselves in their own way, and they supported each other on their respective journeys.

Back then, Bow had struggled with his body, while Adora had faced a quest for perfection. After all, she had never been good enough. If she had been better, her mother would perhaps have recovered. If she had behaved in the right way, she could have stayed in the same foster home longer. If she had just been good enough, someone would have adopted her.

They had been through a lot together. Fortunately, those days were over, and they had found a balance. The smell of waffles evoked all those memories and new ones besides. While Bow was making his famous waffles as he did every weekend, she was sitting at the kitchen table with their children. Sunday morning was a time of joy and laughter. In the midst of their busy daily lives, these moments remained quality time, just for them.

Their life was stable, peaceful, and comfortable, and Adora liked it. Of course, Adora's feelings weren't the same as at the beginning. But that was natural after more than fifteen years, wasn't it? Anyway, on mornings like today, when she was surrounded by her adorable kids, her devoted husband, and the smell of waffles, Adora felt privileged.

When the doorbell rang, Adora was a little surprised. Visits at this hour were uncommon, so it was probably a neighbor who needed something. She waved to her husband to continue cooking. Then, she got up and headed for the front door, leaving her family in the kitchen.

Adora raised a perplexed eyebrow when she found Glimmer at the door. Her purple hair was a mess and she looked tired with dark rings under her eyes. She was wearing her long brown coat over what looked like pajamas. It wasn’t like her to arrive in such a way, so something had definitely happened. Adora hoped it wasn’t anything too serious.

"Glimmer, are you ok-" Adora began in a worried voice.

A sharp slap across her face interrupted her sentence. Adora stepped back in surprise, bringing her hand to her face and opening her eyes wide. She gawked at her friend, bewildered. Glimmer immediately rushed in and grabbed her by the collar. Seeing the hatred in her friend’s eyes, Adora’s mind jumped to the inevitable conclusion, but she still couldn’t face it.

“Damn bitch, I hope you're having fun sleeping with *my wife*!” Glimmer shouted as she pushed her.

Adora fell on the floor and Glimmer stood over her, disgust on her face. It was bad, really bad. She had always known this day could come; she and Catra had been playing with fire for a long time. But she had hoped it wouldn’t happen like this, not in her own house with her family in the next room. There was still a chance to lighten the situation if her friend didn’t know too much. Maybe

she could calm her down and buy some time to talk in a better place.

“Wait, it was a mistake. We were stupid,” Adora apologized, trying to minimize the situation.

“Two years! You have a hell of a nerve,“ Glimmer said with a bitter laugh. It was worse than Adora had expected. Her friend seemed to know everything.

“Glimmer!” A voice shouted from behind Adora, but it didn’t stop Glimmer’s insults.

Panic overtook Adora; she didn’t dare turn her head. If she didn’t look, she could continue to pretend nothing was happening. It was just a dream, a bad dream, and she would wake up soon. She felt the ringing in her ears grow louder, and her breath quickened.

“Glimmer!” the voice shouted again, and Glimmer finally looked up.

The purple-haired woman was talking to someone, but Adora couldn’t hear them. The ringing in her ears drowned out everything else in the room. Unable to stop herself any longer, Adora looked behind her. Her husband was standing in the kitchen doorway with their children behind him. The kids were crying, while her husband spoke with a blank face.

Adora wanted to go comfort them more than anything, but she couldn’t move. Her mind was completely foggy, and her legs refused to cooperate. Turning her head between him and Glimmer, she saw their lips move but she didn’t understand anything. After a while, Glimmer looked at her with a disgusted expression and turned to leave. Her husband grabbed their crying children’s hands and led them toward their rooms.

Alone in the living room, Adora still stared into space between the open front door and the empty kitchen. She didn’t know how long she sat on the floor, too dazed to react. Finally, pushing on her

hands and clutching the back of the sofa, she stood up clumsily. As she sat down on the couch, she tried to compose herself and catch her breath.

The room seemed to move around her, and the ringing in her ears wouldn't fade. As the minutes passed, her breath returned to normal. She gradually pulled herself together. However, it seemed even worse when reality hit her hard. Putting her head in her hands, she began to shiver as a terrible knot formed in her stomach.

A noise drew her attention. She saw Bow close the front door, then sit in the chair in front of her. His eyes were fixed on her feet. She wanted to say something, but she didn't dare open her mouth. They remained stuck in overwhelming silence for what seemed like an eternity for Adora.

Bow finally let out a deep sigh, and simply asked, "Is it true?"

"Yes," Adora huffed. "But listen, I-"

"Dora, no, not now."

Silence fell around them again. Adora would have preferred that he yelled, insulted her, or blamed her. He didn't even look up at her. She opened her mouth several times to speak, but no words came. They remained quiet for far too long for Adora's sanity. Her breathing became heavy, as though a weight pressed down on her chest.

"I'd prefer you stayed somewhere else for a few days," Bow said finally, voice cracked, rubbing his hands together uncomfortably.

"Okay," Adora agreed faintly, feeling her eyes grow wet.

"But it's probably best to keep our schedule with the kids, so as not to upset them further. Can you stick to that?"

"Of course."

Bow’s words were lifeless and his face expressionless. Adora felt guilt wash over her as she looked at him. She didn’t know how she could have done this to him and their family. It wasn’t possible. They could just talk, as they always did, and find a solution together.

“Fine,” he sighed, standing up and running his hand over his face. “So, you'll take Fynn to training tomorrow after school.”

“Wait,” Adora called in a pleading tone as he walked away. “Please, can we talk?”

He glanced at her hesitantly, “I need time to think.”

With tears running down her cheeks, Adora nodded, a terrible knot in her throat. He entered the kitchen without another word. A minute later, she got up and headed to their bedroom. Her mind was empty; she was on autopilot. Grabbing a bag from the closet, she absent-mindedly packed a few clothes and took some toiletries from the bathroom.

When she looked at her phone on the nightstand, there were a few missed calls and several texts from Catra. She didn’t need to call back or read them to know what they were about. She pushed the phone into her pocket and left the room.

She had one more thing to do before leaving and she knew it was the worst of everything. When she put her bag down in the hallway, she tried to dry her eyes and took a deep breath. Then she knocked lightly on the door twice and entered her son’s room. He was sitting on his bed and looked ready to cry again.

To be honest, Adora didn’t remember what either of them said. She explained she had to go away for a few days, but that she would be there to take him to training and everything else. He cried in her arms and Adora’s heart broke in a way she never thought possible. She tried with all her might to keep herself together, as she had to be strong for him. She had no right to break down. His tears and sadness were her own fault.

When she couldn’t bear it any longer, she had to leave the room before she cracked. In the hallway, she composed herself as best she could, before repeating the situation. Tears were already flowing from her daughter's eyes when she entered her room. They talked for a long time, while the kid sobbed in her arms. Adora tried to comfort her, but of course it wasn’t enough. When the bedroom door closed behind her, Adora had never hated herself more.

The house seemed completely silent and empty of life. Adora couldn’t hold back her tears as she grabbed her bag. She walked through the living room and glanced at the kitchen. Bow was sitting at the table with his head resting on his hand, unmoving.

Adora lifted her hand to wave at him, but she stopped short and let her arm fall back. Turning away, she hesitated for another second as she held the door handle. She wondered how the situation could be possible. Cursing herself, she opened the door and stepped out.

Just One Last Night

The move had gone well, at least on the practical side. In a little over half a day, they had packed her things and loaded them in the truck. Catra was surprised at how eight years of her life could be moved so quickly. Logistics had been fairly easy in the end. Her friends Scorpia and Entrapta, and Entrapta's husband Hordak had helped her to pack her clothes, shoes, furniture, toiletries, and everything else efficiently.

However, emotionally, things were quite different. Every second had ripped her heart out. She had only cried three or four times during the day, which wasn't much compared to the week.

It had been only a week since Glimmer had confronted her about her infidelity, and it already seemed like eons. Since then, her wife had refused to take her calls or even respond to her texts. Each day spent away from her wife had broken her heart in ways she hadn't imagined. Halfway through the week, Catra had simply received a cold text telling her to move her things. So, she had spent Saturday packing all her memories into little boxes. Glimmer hadn't even been there when they had moved out. When they were done, Catra had slipped her key into the mailbox.

After unloading the truck at a self-storage container in the late afternoon, Entrapta and her husband had left for their home. Scorpia drove her back to her hotel in the truck. Her burly friend was wearing a purple tank top with blue jeans. She had a light complexion with short, fair hair and dark eyes.

There wasn't much traffic at that time of day, so the ride was peaceful. The cabin was silent, aside from Scorpia who hummed softly to the pop music on the car radio. Catra stared out the side window, lost in thought, her expression blank. She felt empty after the day she had had and held back her tears.

"How are you feeling?" Scorpia asked in a concerned voice as they arrived at the hotel.

“How do you think?” Catra replied sharply, glancing at her. Seriously, how could she be feeling?

Her friend flinched a little, “Yeah, I can imagine.”

Immediately regretting her rude words, Catra let out a deep sigh and pinched the bridge of her nose, “Sorry, I mean… It’s just…”

Scorpia had always been there for her and was too kind for her own good. As soon as she had called her this week, the dynamic woman had offered to help and borrowed a truck from an acquaintance. If Catra couldn’t be grateful to the few people who helped her, she was truly useless. Her friends had avoided asking too many questions throughout the day to spare her, except for Entrapta, of course. However, the former wasn’t aware of that social convention.

Scorpia patted Catra on the shoulder, “It’s nothing, Wildcat. I know.”

“No, it’s not. Thanks for your help today, I’m not sure I could have handled it all on my own,” Catra said with a fuzzy smile.

“Listen, do you want to come over for dinner? That might take your mind off things. Perfuma would be happy to see you.”

Catra hesitated for a second and then said, “No, it’s fine. I just need some time alone.”

“Okay, but I’ll call you tomorrow.”

“Of course you will,” Catra replied with a slight smile as she opened the door and got out of the truck. Then she grabbed her bag from behind the passenger seat.

In the parking lot, Catra waved weakly to her friend as the truck pulled away. To be honest, Catra didn’t want to be alone after her day, but she didn’t want to take advantage of her friend’s kindness. She and Scorpia had met in college, and the woman had remained her closest friend. They had even had a brief

relationship. At the time, Catra had been a complete wreck and had hurt her with her rude attitude. Despite that, Scorpia hadn’t given up on her, and they had remained friends after their breakup. Clearly, Catra had been a shitty girlfriend. In light of recent events, she had to admit she hadn’t really changed with the times.

When the truck vanished behind the pine trees, she wearily picked up her bag and walked toward the entrance. She had been at the hotel for a week. It was a little out of town, surrounded by the forest. A place where she was sure she wouldn’t meet anyone she knew. She didn’t have the strength to explain the situation or find an excuse for her staying there. Ironically, she knew the place well, having visited with Adora.

To the right of the lobby, the hotel had a pub and restaurant. She didn’t feel she could be alone in her room, so she entered the bar without a second thought. It was a typical hotel pub without much character; a long counter on the left and several tables to the right. The place was still quiet in the late afternoon. There were a few customers here and there, mostly couples on a romantic weekend break.

She sat down at a quiet table at the back of the pub and ordered a pint. Hoping to ease some of her sadness, she absent-mindedly sipped her beer while staring out of the window. Catra hadn't been sleeping well since the week before and was very tired. She felt as though her whole life was going up in smoke. Her wife was acting like she didn’t exist, and she couldn’t even blame her. She had hurt the only person who had always been there for her over the past eight years.

Of course, there was still hope. Glimmer was a strong character, but she would calm down sooner or later. Then they could talk things through and settle them. After all, that wasn't their first argument; they had always worked it out. There was nothing different this time, right? Catra put all her hope into that thought, though she wasn’t sure she really believed it.

When her pint was almost done, she pulled her phone out from her pocket and tried to call Glimmer for the hundredth time. As usual, her wife didn't pick up, so she sent her a text to say she had collected her things from their condo. After that, she immediately ordered a second beer. The alcohol didn't make her feel better, quite the opposite; her mood became gloomier with each sip. Deep in thought, she wasn't paying attention to the customers who were gradually filling the place.

Halfway through her second drink, she hesitantly looked at her phone and unlocked it. She knew it was unfair. The blonde had enough problems without this and was probably with her family. But Catra had to talk to someone and couldn't think of anyone else. Without thinking, her fingers tapped out 'Can we meet?' and she sent the text to Adora. Barely a minute later, the answer was already there: 'I don't think that is a good idea.'

Obviously, it was stupid and a really bad idea. However, Catra could help but insist, 'Please, I just need to talk to someone.' After all, she had always known what to say to convince her. A few texts later, Adora agreed to meet her, and Catra sent her the name of the place.

She wasn't sure how long she took, but she was just starting her third pint when she spotted Adora walking into the pub. The blonde's face was drawn and her movements weary. Her whole posture showed how exhausted she was. She was wearing a casual jacket over an old sweater.

However, Catra wasn't paying much attention to those details as she slowly moved past the tipsy zone and began to enter the wasted area. As Adora sat down across the table, she greeted her with a sad smile. She had wanted to see her so badly, but Catra didn't know what to say now. Both remained awkwardly silent for a while, looking at each other.

After the waiter brought her the soda she had ordered, Adora finally asked, "How are you doing?"

Catra could hold back a bitter chuckle, “I’m living a beautiful dream. Can’t you see that?”

“How many beers have you had? I don’t want to talk if you’re drunk.”

The blonde was trying to lecture her or something. Anger flashed through Catra’s mind, and she said in a bitter voice, “What? So I’m not good enough for you anymore?”

Adora let out a deep sign and stood up, “I knew it was a bad idea to come.”

Despite the alcohol, Catra felt a twinge of guilt in her chest and cursed herself. Adora didn’t deserve her attitude. The blonde had been nothing but a sincere friend and much more since they had met. Why was Catra always like this? She hurt everyone who cared about her.

“No, wait!” Catra said with pleading eyes, reaching out a hand to hold her back. “Sorry, you’re right. Can we talk?”

Adora stopped and looked down at her for a few seconds, then she sat back down, “Okay, but I don’t want to stay long. What do you want to talk about?”

Catra just shrugged and pushed her beer away, “I’m not sure. I guess I just wanted to see you. I missed you.”

“Catra, don’t open that door. We're in enough mess without it.”

“I know.”

Yet, it was true. In the middle of this mess, Catra missed Adora, but also her wife and, in general, her whole life. Somehow, she had always lacked the strength to choose between those different lives. Well, there hadn’t been much of a choice; Adora was married. Now, she was afraid she had already lost everything.

They fell back into an uncomfortable babble, just exchanging banalities about the place. Neither of them seemed to be ready to address the elephant in the room. Catra called a waiter and ordered water. He served her quickly and took back her almost-full pint. Most of the tables were filled for dinner, but Catra wasn't hungry and still had a knot in her stomach.

"Are you sleeping here?" Adora asked all the same, waving her hand to point to the room.

Fidgeting with her glass of water, Catra huffed, "For now."

"I'm also sleeping in a hotel," The blonde said, nodding slightly. "How is it going with Glimmer?"

"I moved my stuff today."

"Oh," the blonde blurted, looking down at the table. "Sorry, but things should sort themselves out, shouldn't they?"

Catra wasn't sure if the last words were meant to comfort her or Adora herself. However, that was the problem. Catra didn't know how or even if they could fix it. The idea of losing her wife panicked her more than anything else. Again, she was there talking with Adora. Was she really such a fool? She shook herself, trying not to think about the implications.

"I don't know," Catra huffed, pinching the bridge of her nose. Even though it scared her to say it, it was an honest answer. "What about Bow and you?"

"He doesn't even speak to me," Adora said, leaning forward on the table and resting her head on her hand. "I go home to see the kids every day. We act as if nothing has happened, but he refuses to talk."

"He probably needs time."

"He says so, but…"

"But?"

"Even at our worst, we always talked to each other. Now I don't know what to do."

Catra nodded, pursing her lips in a thin line.

Their discussion then flowed naturally, as it always did. There was no awkwardness between them. It was a relief for Catra to be able to talk freely about the situation, even though the guilt obviously didn't leave her. Adora was the only one who couldn’t judge her. Besides, it was always so easy with her. The blonde also seemed to feel a tad better as the evening progressed. Catra's mind felt less fuzzy as the effect of alcohol wore off.

They discussed many things, but they still avoided talking about themselves.

As the evening went on, Catra eventually asked, "What about us?"

Adora rubbed her eyes and let out a deep sigh, "This is impossible, and you know it."

Of course, Catra already knew the answer. They had already lost so much, but she couldn’t help but ask, "Why did you come tonight?"

"Because I owe you that much, but I have to think about my family."

Catra was aware her questions were nonsense. There was never a ‘them’. They had spent time together, shared intense moments, savored each other in many ways, but what did that really mean? There was no future for them. If she was honest with herself, they would never have had any prospects. Catra was hoping to save her own marriage and couldn’t have everything. This relationship had broken up two couples, but she still couldn’t give it up.

Catra loved her but it was useless. She hated it, but there was only one thing to do. She didn’t want to lose anything else, but

she could not do anything else.

“Could you stay just tonight?” Catra asked in a cracked voice, even though she knew it was unfair.

"Catra, I can't. We can't," Adora said with a pleading look. “I should go.”

“Please, just this last time, I’m not sure I can be alone,” Catra added, placing her hand on Adora’s. Her words were sadly sincere after the day she had had.

The blonde gazed at her for a long time with her tired eyes, then sighed, “Okay.”

They didn’t even finish their drink. Catra grabbed her bag, and they went up to her room. They walked slowly, sharing a few words in low voices here and there. They had followed the same path many times, but their mood was very different tonight. There was no desire or joy in this moment, only melancholy.

Their movements, their looks and everything else felt like a farewell. They just slept against each other, barely even cuddling each other. However, this was the first peaceful night Catra had had in a week. When she opened her eyes in the morning, the other side of the bed was already cold. Another part of her life was gone, and she began to cry silently.

Unfortunately Nothing Is Broken

It had been almost two weeks, and Adora still hadn't talked to her husband. Sure, they exchanged a few words about daily life when she brought back the kids or came to the house, but he refused to get into the main point. Adora couldn't bear it any longer, so she called him to ask for a serious conversation. Finally, he agreed to meet her at her hotel while the children were at his parents' house on a Saturday afternoon.

As she was waiting for him, Adora was nervous. She had asked for this discussion, but she was afraid of the possible outcome. She walked up and down in the narrow room which had been her home since he had learned about her infidelity. Her hotel was located downtown near her workplace. The place was clean and cheap. Her room was simple, with a bed that was too firm and a tiny desk with an uncomfortable seat. The only window overlooked the street. When she had rented it, she hadn't thought she would be living there for two weeks.

When he knocked on the door, Adora took a deep breath and opened it. Bow didn't seem to have slept well the night before. His eyes were red and his expression was haggard. He greeted her with a slight nod and entered as she stepped aside to make way for him. Looking around, he seemed to take in the room with distracted eyes.

Adora offered him the seat while she sat down on the bed. They looked at each other without knowing what to do for a while.

"Nice room," Bow finally said, scanning it again.

Adora snorted humorlessly with an embarrassed smile, "Yeah, it reminds me of our university's dorms."

"It's true there is a certain resemblance with the uncomfortable furniture," He said, tapping his fingers against the seat.

She nodded slowly, then finally asked, “We can’t keep this up. What do we do, Bow?”

“I don’t know what to think. This whole situation was you, so what do you want?” He said in a sad voice, but without malice.

Twisting uncomfortably on the bed, Adora looked at her husband, searching for a response. There was no anger or hatred in his eyes, just exhaustion. She had thought about this question for weeks but hadn’t found an answer. There was only one thing she was sure of: she didn’t want to lose her family.

“I don’t know either. I hurt you. I’m not in position to ask anything of you.” Adora said, and her voice cracked at the end of her sentence. “But I need you to talk to me, because I’m completely terrified.”

Bow cocked his head, raising a surprised eyebrow, “What are you afraid of?”

“That you’ll use it to take the kids away from me or to turn them against me.”

“Please Dora,” he huffed, running his hand over his face. “We’re sensible enough not to put the children in the middle of it all.”

Old habits die hard. Even in that moment, he was trying to comfort her however he could. Adora felt relieved to hear it, even though she had already known it. Her husband always put their family first. However, she had hurt him so much that doubt had crept in. She let out a deep sigh she seemed to have been holding back since he had found out.

“Despite everything, sure, we are,” Adora said, nodding slightly.

“But I don’t understand when or how I lost you,” he added after a few seconds. “We were good, weren't we?”

“We were fine. You didn’t lose me,” Adora replied in a pensive voice, catching his look. She had wondered about this many times

over the past two years, without really finding an answer. “Things just changed.”

“After almost twenty years, it seems natural that some things change, doesn’t it?” He hesitated for a moment, but finally asked with a nervous face, “Is it me? Is it because of my transition.”

Adora felt a cold sensation grip her chest and her lungs emptied of oxygen. They couldn’t open this door. Even though it was more than a decade earlier, she knew he would never be completely free of doubts. The process had been emotionally complex for them both and, of course, physically exhausting for him. However, they had taken every step together. Not everything has been easy, far from it, but they got through their problems, doubts, and fears.

She could try to reassure him all day, but she had learnt that wasn’t the most effective method. In moments like this, Adora had to be tough for their own sake, even though it meant being hurtful in some way.

“No Bow, not everything is about you. Stop being self-centered. It’s about me, about both of us,” Adora said in a sharp voice, narrowing her eyes. She didn’t like her own words, but it was better than leaving him with his doubts.

Bow flinched, rubbing the back of his neck, but he seemed relieved at the same time, “Yeah, of course, it’s about both of us. I still love you.”

“I will always love you in some way too. But our relationship has faded over the past few years. Try to be honest, didn’t you feel it?”

He remained silent for a while, turning his head and looking out the window, then he said, “I knew it wasn’t the same anymore, but I didn’t think it was that bad. Why didn’t you talk to me? We have always found solutions together.”

“I was afraid of losing everything. I didn’t see what we could have done.”

“I don’t know exactly. Maybe we could have reached some sort of agreement to allow you to find a balance.”

Adora couldn’t hold back a laugh, her eyes wide, “What are you talking about? Can you imagine us having an open marriage or swinging? Seriously, Bow, could you handle it?”

Adora already knew the answer. Her reaction wasn’t malicious, but the proposal was simply nonsense. Her husband was the most sappy, faithful, and romantic person she had ever met. After all their years together and two kids, he remained completely mushy, writing her little notes and never forgetting their various anniversaries.

“No, no, I don’t think I could,” Bow said with a long sigh.

“Of course, you couldn’t, we couldn’t. We don’t have that type of relationship. Yet we can’t go on like this,” Adora replied, shaking her head slowly.

“So, what are you suggesting? Are you talking about divorce?”

A shiver ran down Adora’s back. There were some words that were hard to take back once they were out. Naturally, she had thought about it a few times since she had been in a relationship with Catra. But at the time, it was nothing more than a meaningless fantasy. It was not a realistic thought; Catra was married and so was she. They obviously had no future together. Their relationship was just a digression in her life. So, a divorce made no sense.

But the word coming sounded different from Bow’s mouth. The concept took on a new reality in Adora’s mind. The idea was terrifying. It meant their whole life was about to be turned upside down. Yet, it seemed to be the inevitable outcome of the last few years.

“I think we should consider it,” Adora huffed, pinching the bridge of her nose.

“Couldn't we try to fix it?” Bow asked, rubbing his hair nervously.

“Nothing is broken. It just-”

“Things have changed.”

Adora nodded and gave him a sad smile.

The conversation had been difficult until there, but then it flowed. As they discussed practical matters, they regained a bit of their natural complicity. Of course, the tone was still sad, and they gave each other many knowing looks. However, clearing the air, even to this uncomfortable conclusion, gave them a strange kind of relief.

They talked for a few hours and the children were the main subject. Their well-being remained the top priority for them both. This would be a huge change for the family, but maybe it was the best solution in some ways. At least, they tried to convince themselves of that. Adora and Bow didn’t want to pretend to be together until they hated each other.

When Bow left late that afternoon, Adora felt exhausted, but surprisingly peaceful. She dropped onto the bed and let out a deep sigh. After weeks, action finally replaced her anguish thoughts. Tomorrow, they would talk things through with their children as it was important to clear things up as soon as possible.

The situation was hard, but at least it was clear. There were many practical issues to be addressed in the coming weeks. However, Adora liked to be busy. It kept her from spiraling about everything. She would have to find a new apartment first. It was better for everyone if Bow stayed at their house with the children. For the moment, Adora would continue to visit every day to be with the kids.

She was still trying to see this as the best choice. A month earlier, she would never have believed her life would follow this path. Her marriage was over, her relationship with Catra had ended, and she had broken up the marriage of her closest friend. The whole thing was just a huge waste for everyone. A chapter of her life was ending. The next few months would be complicated, but she needed to focus on her family. Even though everything would be different, her family would remain her family. Nothing else was important.

The Other Side of The Mirror

Glimmer had always been proud of the way she dealt with breakups. When her first boyfriend had broken up with her in secondary school, she had barely cried. Then she had thrown herself into something useful. Her days and nights had been devoted to her passion for gymnastics. She had trained intensively for weeks, improving her technique and resistance. Of course, this overtraining had eventually injured her, and then she had a limp for almost two months.

When her college girlfriend had dumped her in second year, she had sobbed for a few days. Then she had gotten a grip on herself and had buried herself in her study. She had spent many evenings and sometimes nights in the campus library revising for all her classes. Three weeks later, she had been sitting in the library restroom, trying to calm a panic attack.

So, when she found out her wife was cheating on her, she was totally ready to cope with that. Her whole world collapsed in a few hours. After their breakup, she cried endlessly and moped around for a week without leaving the apartment. When Catra had moved her things out, she didn’t have the strength to stay in their half-empty condo all the time. So she dove into her work in a fanatical way.

For a month now, Glimmer had been arriving at her office before the sun and leaving late in the evening. At least, on the nights she did leave. She had indeed spent a few sleeping on the couch in her office. However, it was a useful and healthy method to get through the day. Work was going well. On top of that, she could focus on a myriad of daily life details. There was always something to do and she didn't need anyone’s approval. That was the benefit of being a CEO and part owner.

This was the third time she had looked at the time on her phone in the last twenty minutes. There was no one in the building but her on that late Saturday afternoon.

It was the perfect time to read the latest sales report. The results were good – excellent, if she was honest. Sales for their new product were above expectations. She made a mental note to congratulate the sales team next week. Glimmer was pleased as she scanned the report on her screen a second time. The company was going well and that was the most important thing. Really, what else did she need to be happy?

After all, sales reports didn't betray you after eight years, when you thought you knew them. A customer statistic didn't claim to want to start a family while sleeping with your best friend. A benefit chart didn't pretend to love you until it broke your heart. Her work was the only thing that mattered right now. She was perfectly fine with this. Absolutely fine.

Stopping her reading, she grabbed her phone again and let out a deep sigh. It was almost time. The pub wasn't far from her office, but she was already late. She had been trying to avoid this meeting for two weeks, but she couldn't put it off forever. They had to talk about the whole mess. Rubbing her eyes to wake herself up, she stood up and stretched.

A few minutes later, she was slowly making her way to the meeting place. The weather was mild for spring, without a cloud in sight, which didn't suit her mood. She hesitated for a second in front of the pub, running her hand over her face. Customers were enjoying the late afternoon sun on the narrow terrasse. However, she didn’t see who she was looking for, so she entered the pub.

The place was a typical pub, with wooden tables and a long counter at the back. Most of the tables were full, but she spotted him immediately, sitting near the windows. Bow waved at her with a weak, fuzzy smile. Glimmer sat down at the table with a tired greeting. After a few awkward seconds, he shared some civilities and they made small talk about the weather.

Small talk seemed to be the usual protocol when hanging out with a friend. At least, with your longest and closest friend, whose partner had cheated on him with yours. There was probably a

book of etiquette on the subject. The history teacher in Bow would certainly have loved to spend hours in the archives to find out. After a waitress brought their drinks, they finally stopped beating around the bush.

“You look like you’re about to collapse,” Bow commented, voice free of malice.

“Thanks, you look like shit too,” Glimmer huffed, narrowing her eyes. “We’re not in college anymore. I know how to take care of myself.”

“Sure.”

“Yes, that’s for *sure* ! Don’t you have enough to deal with yourself right now?”

He let out a deep sigh and ran her hand over his face, “We’re separated.”

“I hope you are from that whore.”

“Hey! She’s not-”

“Don’t you dare ‘ *hey’* me about her! I don’t even know why you’re trying to defend her."

Since her breakup, Glimmer hadn’t been able to focus on anything but her wife's betrayal. However, she hadn’t forgotten her friend – her best friend – had stabbed her in the back. They had known each other for almost twenty years. Glimmer was her son’s godmother. But that filthy traitor had slept with her wife.

“I’m certainly not defending her," Bow protested, waving his hands. "But I don’t want to make matters worse.”

Glimmer snorted, giving him a doubtful look, "Worse? Are you kidding me? She cheated on you. She slept with *my wife* !"

"It's not so simple. There are the kids. I can't throw everything away like you always do."

She opened her eyes wide. Then she frowned deeply, crossed her arms over her chest, and leaned back in her seat, "Oh, sorry, how could I complain? After all, I don't even have children. Thanks for the reminder."

"Please Glim, I don't mean it like that and you know it."

Of course, she knew that. He had always been the most considerate and calm person she knew since they met in elementary school. Lots of things had changed, but his character remained the same. She could be mad at a lot of people – her wife for cheating on her, her best friend for breaking up her marriage, her friend Scorpia for introducing her to Catra, and herself for being so stupid and blind – but Bow was certainly not on the list. They were in the same boat, after all.

Uncrossing her arms, she leant forward and said, "Damn Bow, I don't understand how you can stay so calm."

"It’s already complicated enough, and I don't want to-"

"Making things worse, blah blah blah. I know your spiel, but that doesn't change the situation. Aren’t you mad?"

"What do you think? Do you think I don't feel hurt, betrayed? I’m just trying to stay functional," he said in a tense voice, then leaning back in his seat. "So, are you satisfied?"

"I feel less alone," she said with a wry smile, grabbing her pint and sipping it.

Grabbing his own pint, he shook his head, "Nothing changes. You’re still a brat.”

Glimmer shrugged and continued to smirk. They bantered about everything except their marriages for a while. She felt relieved and more relaxed as the atmosphere grew lighter. She and Bow

had always talked so easily, although they were polar opposites. In this time of chaos in her life, she was pleased to find comfort with her old friend. However, this was only a diversion; they couldn't avoid their reason for meeting for too long.

"What about you? How is it going with Catra?" Bow asked as he placed his half-empty pint on the table.

"Catra who?" Glimmer said with indifference.

He rolled his eyes with a sigh, "Glim."

"We're going nowhere. I haven't seen her since. She moved her stuff out."

She hadn't responded to her wife's calls or texts for a month. After all, she had nothing to say. Her wife had shattered everything they had built, but it was still so painful. When she came back to their apartment emptied of her wife's things, it felt like someone had pulled out her heart.

Glimmer and Bow chatted about their last few weeks, going over the latest developments in their marriage.

"Seriously, you haven't even talked? Can't you try to save something?" Bow asked hesitantly.

"What are you talking about?" She said, frowning.

"I mean maybe you could fix it? She made a mistake-"

"What mistake? We're not talking about two tipsy women making out. They've been sleeping together for two years. Two years! It's basically bigamy."

"I know," he huffed, resting his head on his hand. "But I'm trying to understand. When I talked with Dora, she said that things have changed."

“Don’t waste your time trying to understand that dirty liar. They’re nothing but floozies.”

“Hey.”

Glimmer pointed at him, “What did I say about ‘ *hey’* ?”

Their conversation flowed into their disappointment, frustration, and anger. The relaxed and noisy atmosphere of the pub contrasted with their mood. They both needed to release the tension of the last few weeks. Even though Glimmer hadn’t wanted to come initially, she felt genuinely relieved to find a sympathetic ear to listen to her.

“How are the kids handling the situation?” She asked as she was finishing her drink.

“They’re struggling, but we’re trying to help them as best we can. They’ll have two homes now. They’re setting up their bedrooms in Dora’s new apartment today.” Bow replied, absent-mindedly fiddling with his glass.

“That’s not so bad under the circumstances, I guess,” she said, nodding slowly. “By the way, I’m sorry for that day. I shouldn’t have blown up in front of them.”

“No, you shouldn’t,” he said seriously, looking into her eyes, before continuing in a softer tone, “Though I do understand you weren’t in your right mind.”

To be honest, she didn’t remember everything that happened that day. The anger and sadness had simply erased everything else in her mind. After leaving Bow’s house, she had driven downtown and walked aimlessly for hours. Night had already fallen when she returned to their empty apartment.

“It wasn’t the greatest day of my life,” Glimmer said with a sad smile, shaking her head.

“I get it. It wasn’t for me either,” Bow replied, finishing his drink. ”Would you like to come for lunch tomorrow? Maia and Fynn would be happy to see you.”

“Even after the last time?”

“I’m not going to lie to you, they were scared. But they adore you, so it would be a good opportunity to fix it,” he said with an encouraging look. “And I was serious, you don’t look well. It would be good to take your mind off things for a while.”

Leaning back in her seat, Glimmer let out a loud sigh and ran a hand through her short purple hair. It was tough, but she knew how to deal with it. She certainly didn’t need to be patronized. However, he looked worried about her and probably also needed to take his mind off things.

“Okay, but I can’t promise to be the most pleasant company right now,” she said begrudgingly after a while.

Bow nodded and gave her a satisfied smile.

In The Looks of Others

Catra's new apartment was quite convenient. The place was located downtown, but on a quiet street just a few minutes away from her office. The building was modern with an elevator and an underground parking lot. For a one-bedroom apartment, the kitchen was well-equipped and the bathroom spacious. Clearly, the place had many advantages. However, even after almost two months, she wouldn’t call it home.

After all, there were only a few places she had called home, and they were always with her wife. All her other places had been convenient for sleeping or storing her things, but they weren’t home. When they started living together, she had felt comfortable and had been able to let down her defenses in front of someone else for the first time in her life.

Sitting at her kitchen table, Catra was re-reading the documents for the fourth time that day. She had received the divorce papers three days earlier, but she hadn’t had the nerve to read them. Part of her had still secretly hoped the situation with Glimmer would settle down.

Of course, it was just a sweet dream, and the papers in her hands showed beyond any doubt it was really over. Even though she had already known it, a feeling of sadness weighed on her chest. Her wife hadn’t spoken to her for two months. Apparently, the eight years they spent together were not worth a single hour to try to save it. Catra didn’t even get a chance to explain, although she wasn’t sure what she would have. She knew she had no one to blame but herself for all this mess, but it was tough.

Shaking her head, she put the papers down on the table and stood up. She didn’t want to mope around all night. For the first time since her move, she had accepted Scorpia's invitation to dinner at her and Perfuma’s house. It was a good opportunity to clear her head for a few hours, and she sincerely needed it.

Her life was taking her down a new path and she needed to deal with it. She knew that, but it was easier said than done. She could try to convince herself for one night, at least. Grabbing a bottle of red wine from the kitchen counter, she put on her jacket and left the condo.

Her friends' apartment was located a few minutes away. In the middle of spring, the weather was mild. There were many people strolling and having dinner on the terraces of the restaurants. Life seemed to have started again after the long winter. This atmosphere was fortifying and infectious. Catra thought she could soon start hiking or perhaps running in the mountains. After all, there was so much to do, and she needed something to look forward to.

Sure, she would probably mope around with the divorce papers tomorrow, but she wanted to make the most of the evening. Since her move, Scorpia had invited her over several times. Her friend was always thoughtful and supportive, in her own somewhat exaggerated way. However, Catra had declined each time, and they had just had a drink here and there. She hadn't felt like spending a whole evening with people. Besides, Scorpia's wife was one of Bow and Glimmer's oldest friends, so it was a bit awkward. But tonight was different, it was her fresh start.

When she rang her friends' doorbell, she was almost smiling. Scorpia immediately opened the door and welcomed her with friendly words and a warm look. The burly woman was a bit excessive in her friendly attitude, but it was always refreshingly genuine. She was wearing simple blue jeans and a pink flannel shirt, but she looked elegant as always.

In the living room, Perfuma was serving snacks on the coffee table. The woman was tall and thin. She had a tanned complexion and her brown eyes were relaxed. Her long blonde hair fell around her shoulders. She was wearing a simple green dress.

The place was on the third floor of an old building, but it was bright with many plants and comfortable furniture. The main room

was split between a large living space with a couch and an open kitchen with a long, wooden table. Catra was familiar with the place and felt comfortable there.

As soon as Catra entered, the blonde raised her head and a slight frown passed across her face. However, the expression was quickly replaced by a faint smile, and she greeted her guest. Catra dropped her jacket on a chair and sat down without ceremony. Her hosts opened the bottle she had brought while they chatted away.

"I'm so happy you finally came," Scorpia said as she placed a glass of wine in front of her and sat down on the sofa.

"Yeah, it’s been a while," Catra said with a light nod. She briefly remembered the last time had been Glimmer, but she pushed the thought away. "Thanks for the invitation."

Perfuma sat down next to her wife and said, "You’re welcome. I haven't seen you since New Year at Adora and Bow’s.”

Catra just hummed. She didn’t want to go on those kinds of memories.

Scorpia awkwardly coughed and asked, “How is your work going at the moment?”

Fortunately, the conversation followed a more comfortable path after that. Her hosts explained to her the latest events of their daily life and their plans for their next vacations. As usual, Catra listened more than she spoke, but she enjoyed herself. The two women had the sensitivity not to ask her too many questions.

They finished their pre-dinner drink in the living room, then settled at the table. Scorpia had cooked lasagna with vegetables on the side. It was a tasty meal and Catra really enjoyed it, not just for the food but also for the friendly atmosphere. The discussion covered various light topics and they laughed a lot. Truly, the night was going well.

As they finished the main course, Scorpia brought up a more serious, yet joyful, subject. She announced she and her wife would soon start a family. The couple had begun the adoption procedure a month earlier. It wasn't really a surprise to Catra; she knew her friends had been talking about it for a while. Scorpia explained their plans with her usual enthusiasm.

"Congrats, this is great news," Catra said in a cheerful voice. With their patience and empathy, she knew they would be fantastic parents.

"Thank you. We've been thinking about it for years, but the time seemed right," Scorpia said, taking her wife's hand.

"This is an important step, it's natural you would take your time to think about it," Catra commented with a supportive smile. After all, she had experienced it firsthand.

"Clearly, some people could have thought it through a little more," Perfuma blurted out.

"What?" Catra said, narrowing her eyes and catching Perfuma's look.

Of course, Catra knew exactly what was going on. She didn't want to have this conversation, but she certainly wasn't letting herself be insulted. The blonde always seemed to be a peaceful person, but sometimes she was a bit too direct.

"Perfuma, please," Scorpia said, giving her an imploring look.

"Yeah, sorry babe. This is not the place," Perfuma said, shaking her head and taking her wife's hand.

"No, no, no, say what you want to say," Catra said sharply, leaning forward. "What did you mean by that?"

"You know exactly what I mean. Seriously, who would want to start a family when you're sleeping around?" Perfuma replied in a firm voice, letting go of her wife's hand to point at Catra.

Her life didn’t concern anyone, but Catra couldn’t help turning her head to avoid her friend's gaze. She didn’t need anyone to tell her how badly she had screwed up. Anger fought with guilt in her mind. It had been a mistake to come tonight; she should have stayed home alone.

“It’s none of your business. I don’t need you to lecture me,” Catra said, leaning back in her seat and crossing her arms.

“Babe, please,” Scorpia said, trying again to calm her wife.

Perfuma turned to her wife, “Why are you defending her? Someone needs to tell her. You saw how much she hurt Glimmer.”

“We didn’t know everything. We don’t get to judge.”

The two women argued about her while Catra remained silent. The words about Glimmer were like a punch in the gut. Of course, she imagined her wife wasn’t doing well, but it was another thing to hear it from others. She tried to keep a neutral face, but she felt her eyes moisten slightly.

“That’s right. You don’t know anything,” Catra finally protested, but her voice was shaky.

“I’ve seen enough. You ruined your own marriage and Adora’s family.”

“Shut up!” Catra said, face turning pale.

Glancing at Catra, Scorpia placed a hand on her wife’s forearm, “Stop it.”

“No babe, she treated you like shit and took advantage of you when you were together. She hasn't changed. She’s toxic.”

Catra pushed back her seat and stood up, “Go to hell, I don’t have to listen to this.”

Catra grabbed her jacket from the armchair and rushed out of the apartment without thinking twice. She certainly wouldn't give this bitch who pretended to be her friend the satisfaction of cracking in front of her. Scorpia called out to her, but she didn't look back. She could hear the two women arguing behind her.

In the hallway, she frantically pressed the elevator button. She wanted to leave as soon as possible. A few seconds later, when the door didn't open, she turned around and went down the stairs. After only a few steps, her legs turned to jelly, and she sat down on the stairs. Placing her head in her hands, she breathed deeply but couldn't hold back her tears.

Catra had broken her own marriage and couldn't deny it, but even though she had helped to ruin Adora's family, she hadn't been alone. There had been two in this story, but obviously everyone blamed her. Perfuma even brought up her two-decades-old history with Scorpia.

Her mind was spiraling when she felt someone sit down next to her. She didn't need to look to know who it was.

"Are you coming back for dessert or will you have it here?" Scorpia asked awkwardly.

Catra just huffed in answer.

"I get it, but you know her. Perfuma gets carried away sometimes. But she wants to apologize."

Catra remained quiet for a moment, then finally said weakly, "She is right. I hurt everyone around me. I'm toxic."

After all, it was so simple. She was toxic to everyone. Her wife was gone, Adora was gone. They were only the newest names on a long list that had been running since her birth. Aside from Scorpia, and maybe her other friend Entrapta, she never kept a connection for long. However, both seemed impervious to her attitude, each in their own way. Sooner or later, she would hurt most people, or they would hurt her, and it would be over.

As those thoughts overwhelmed her, Scorpia put a hand on her shoulder. The contact grounded her and she finally turned to look at her friend. The burly blonde looked at her tenderly.

“Stop it,” Scorpia said in a firm voice, before continuing more gently. “I saw you with Glimmer enough to know you were many things, but not toxic. You dropped your whole life to follow her here. You supported her while she was taking over her parents’ business.”

“Now you’re seeing the result,” Catra protested waving her hands. “I hurt her anyway, and I hate myself for it.”

“If you were really toxic, you wouldn't feel so sad or guilty.”

“I cheated on her.”

“Yes, you did, and I can’t pretend to understand. But I’m- No, we’re here to listen if you want.”

Catra didn’t need anyone to listen to her. She was fine, perfectly fine. She could handle her problems on her own. However, she was also smart enough to know when she was lying to herself. Nothing had been going right for two months, but she didn’t know how to start fixing it.

“I hope the dessert is good,” Catra said, wiping her eyes with the back of her hand.

“Sure, Perfuma baked her chocolate tart.”

“Your wife is a bitter one and doesn’t hold back.”

“Sometimes,” Scorpia said with a knowing smile. “But she's offered to meditate with you to fix things.”

Catra snorted, as she stood up, “In her dreams.”

A Long List of New Habits

The road wasn't particularly quiet as Adora was driving in the late afternoon. Maia and Fynn were arguing loudly in the backseat about some TV shows or other. Well, that was what she understood between the yells. They were particularly restless today – they had been all weekend, if she was honest.

After a while, Adora told them to calm down in her serious voice with a stern look in the rearview mirror. The kids quickly fell silent with a few mumbles of protest. Adora was pleased to find some tranquility, even though she knew it wouldn't last long. Her serious voice almost always worked, so she considered it a kind of superpower.

She had picked up her son from his practice after running some errands with her daughter after school. The next stop would be at their house – well, her children's house. After all, she hadn't lived there for four months, but she still called it home sometimes. Monday was their switch day, and the children would spend that week with Bow. Next week, they would switch back to the new apartment. At first, the situation had been a bit complicated for them, but they seemed to have found their feet in the last few weeks.

As soon as she parked in front of the house, the kids jumped out of the car.

"Hey! Don't forget your bags," Adora called unsuccessfully. They were already running into the house. Letting out a deep sigh, she got out of the car to unload their luggage.

"I knew it was you when I saw two noisy shadows crossing the living room," Bow said, as he stepped out and reached out to help her.

"Your kids are unbearable sometimes," she said, giving him the first bag.

"Oh, so *they're my* kids now."

"For the next seven days, yes. I'll go relax at the gym and let you deal with them," she replied with a knowing smile.

Adora would do anything for her children, but sometimes the break was welcome. When they outnumbered her, it was difficult. It was one change among many she hadn't anticipated before their separation. There were so many new habits to create and endless tiny ways to adapt. Fortunately, Adora and Bow had always planned their daily life thoroughly and easily developed a comfortable routine. In fact, Adora thought it might be one of the sources of the current situation.

"Very kind of you," he said with a faint smile. "By the way, the last adjustments have been made. You'll receive the divorce papers soon."

"Fine, that's fine," she stammered, grabbing the second bag from the trunk.

"Is it?"

The divorce paper was just another step in their separation, but it was still an emotional one. However, they were past the point of lying to themselves. She thought for a second and said firmly, "Yes, it is."

"I think so too."

They brought their children's luggage into the house, and she said goodbye to Maia and Fynn for the week. Even though there were phone and video calls, it wasn't easy not to see them every day. However, it was becoming a habit like everything else. A few minutes later, she was driving to the gym in a pleasantly silent car.

When she parked downtown, she grabbed her gym bag from the trunk. Sport had always been one of her favorite ways to unwind. She enjoyed these relaxing moments when she could clear her

mind and focus on herself. Amid her daily life, it was a more-than welcome break.

However, she had also had to change her habits. For the past few months, she had only been going to the gym on weekdays to avoid Glimmer, who usually worked out on weekends. Ideally, she would have chosen a different gym, but she hoped to finish her annual subscription. After all, the move out and all the changes had taken their toll on her finances.

On this late spring Monday, the gym was quiet and plenty of gym equipment was free. The fervor of the beginning of the year had long since subsided. Adora immediately spotted an exercise bike in a quiet corner and settled in. She preferred to start with a slow warm-up, before moving on to the treadmill and bench. The feeling of well-being came over her quickly once she started.

However, her serenity didn't last long. She had barely been pedaling for ten minutes when she spotted two tough eyes gazing at her from across the room. Glimmer was standing with a towel in hands near the door of the locker room. Her eyes were full of hatred and disgust. A shiver ran down Adora's spine. She looked at the woman, stunned, unsure what to do. While her mind searched for a reaction, she couldn't help but notice her friend – well, her former friend – looked healthy. Her cheeks were still red, probably from her training. Her hair was longer than the last time she had seen her.

After a few too many seconds, the purple-haired woman turned away and entered the changing room. The brief moment shook Adora up more than she could have imagined. She knew they would run into each other sooner or later, of course. However, she hadn't been ready for it. At least Glimmer hadn't crossed the room to slap her, but the look on her face had been like a punch to the stomach.

Stopping pedaling, Adora got off the bike and absentmindedly wiped her forehead with her towel. She leaned back on the bike, deep in thought, sipping from her water flask. The image

remained in her mind, but there was also something else. Glimmer's anger was no surprise, and she couldn't say she didn't deserve it. However, Adora was also intrigued.

For months, she hadn't heard from Glimmer or Catra. Catra had always stayed away from social media and Glimmer had blocked Adora on everything. Her last night with Catra had been more of a farewell than anything else. The brunette had had enough to deal with without Adora's presence. With Glimmer, she didn't know how to ask about her, without seeming too awkward or, worse, creepy.

She wondered how her friends' marriage was going. Glimmer had asked her wife to move out, but that had probably been just a knee-jerk reaction. The purple-haired woman had always had a quick temper, but then she calmed down and had plenty of common sense. The two women had probably fixed their relationship. Indeed, one only had to see them together to know how much they loved each other.

Certainly, they had to have fixed their marriage, which made Adora strangely uncomfortable. She felt a pang of jealousy in her chest, even if she couldn't understand why.

Was it because her friends could have fixed their marriage and she hadn't been able to? No, she and Bow had done the right thing. Even though it involved a lot of changes, it was the right decision for them. Was she upset with Catra about her own divorce? No, she had made her own choices and had known the risks of their relationship. There was no one to blame but herself.

So what was it? Adora could see no possible explanation. Looking around as she sipped her water, she saw the purple-haired woman rushing out of the gym, her bag over her shoulder.

Was it because other arms could hold the most beautiful, clever, and funny person she had ever met? Adora shook her head at this stupid thought. She couldn't be jealous of Glimmer for that. After

all, there was no comparison between them; Glimmer was Catra's wife. Adora had only been a moment of madness. Well, a rather long period.

Sure, Catra had sometimes said she loved her, but that was probably just smooth-talk. Adora had never dared to utter the same words. It wasn't that she didn't, but that it seemed unfair to say it considering their situation. Looking back, she wished she had said something, but it was too late. That part of her life was over, like so many others.

Anyway, there was no room for jealousy. She had to be pleased for her friends. It was the only reasonable attitude and should be easy. Shaking herself, she stood up straight and scanned the room for her next exercise. She picked a treadmill, tried to focus on her training and began to run at a leisurely pace. However, two mismatched eyes, sky blue and light amber, were haunting her mind.

On a Ground Far Too Hard

Over the years, the mountains had gradually instilled themselves in Catra. When she had first moved to the area, it had made her a bit uncomfortable. There was something oppressive about those huge, rough shapes all around, masking the horizon. Catra had grown up on the south coast. The horizon had always been visible. Her feet had known more sandy beaches than stony paths.

However, she had found her feet with time. The mountains had become less menacing and more appealing. She had started running on those sloping paths, hiking to these summits, and even trying her hand at rock climbing with a few colleagues. During the harsh winters, Glimmer had introduced her to cross-country skiing and long evenings by the fireplace.

Over the last few months, she had sometimes thought about returning to the coast, but nothing. No one was waiting for her there. After five years, her job, friends, and whole life were here. She really felt at home.

So, that summer Sunday, waking up at sunrise and hiking two hours to reach an accessible top hadn't bothered her. However, another thing did. She was tired of sitting with her eyes closed on an uncomfortable rock for ages.

"Could you have picked a worse place for it?" Catra complained, twisting to find a better position.

"Focus on your breathing and forget everything else," Perfuma said in a relaxed tone beside her.

"I don't think my breathing is going to soften the ground."

"You're simply not breathing correctly."

"I've been breathing for almost four decades, so I've some experience in the matter," Catra said, opening one eye to watch

the other woman's reaction.

The blonde stared at her with narrowed eyes and huffed. Catra cracked a wry smile. It was always so easy to get under Perfuma's skin. Catra loved banter. It was a way of life. Besides, she had had plenty of opportunities to practice with the blonde over the past three months.

Catra didn't know exactly how, but Perfuma had convinced her to try the meditation. So, every week, they got together to sit on the grass and close their eyes, as Catra liked to describe it. Even though she wouldn't admit it, she had gradually discovered relaxation in their sessions. What's more, she had also found a true friend. Perfuma had been a second-hand friend, or her friend's wife, before their weekly practices. Since their argument, they were getting along better. Clearly, insulting each other seemed to be an effective way to become friends.

"Can you stop being a brat for a second?" Perfuma said in a frustrated voice.

"I don't know, can you stop being so dense?" Catra replied, cocking her head.

"I'm not-"

Clearing her throat beside them, Scorpia asked awkwardly, "Is it like this every time?"

"Yes," Perfuma and Catra replied at the same time.

"Oh okay. Just asking."

Scorpia didn't usually meditate with them, but this was a special Sunday. Her friends had invited Catra on a hike and they had decided to relax on the stony summit after their climb. The landscape was clear all around them and they could see the other mountains and the town in the distance. It was a beautiful summer day for a hike.

Of course, Catra knew the date was no coincidence. Scorpia was kind, but not exactly subtle when she suggested the hike. It was Catra and Glimmer's ninth wedding anniversary. Well, that would have been if they hadn’t divorced two months earlier. To be honest, she was pleased with the invitation. This anniversary brought back a lot of memories she wasn't ready to face yet. She was glad to simply hike and focus on anything else.

While they were still bantering about the discomfort of the ground, Catra's phone rang. She stood up and stretched, then grabbed her phone from her bag. Looking at her phone, she was ready to hang up; she didn't want to talk to anyone in the middle of their hike. People could wait until tonight, or maybe even tomorrow.

However, she froze when she read the name on the screen. Her former father-in-law, Micah, was calling her. If he was calling her, then something had maybe happened to Glim. The idea sent an icy shiver through her body.

Picking up, she took a few steps away to be quiet, and hurriedly asked, "Hey Micah, what happened? Is Glim okay?"

"Everything is fine. There is nothing wrong with Glim," Micah immediately said in a calm voice. "Sorry, I didn't mean to worry you. Hi, by the way."

"Fine, fine," Catra said, running a hand over her face and letting out a sigh. She felt relieved, but remained suspicious, "Why are you calling me? Did Glim ask you to?"

"No, she didn’t ask me anything. Am I not allowed to call my daughter-in-law to catch up?"

Catra knew she couldn’t ask about Glimmer. When they had signed the divorce paper, it had been the first time she had seen her since their breakup. As always, her wife looked good in a professional suit. She had let her silky hair grow. Catra hadn’t stopped staring at her throughout the meeting, while her wife

hadn't even looked at her once. She hadn't said a word and had left the room immediately afterwards. There wasn't much to say, but Catra had been hoping for at least a glance. After eight years, their relationship deserved it, even if she had ruined everything.

"If you haven't noticed, I'm no longer your in-law," Catra said in an uneasy voice.

“I think I’ve heard something about it,” Micah said, soberly.

“I can imagine,” she huffed sadly, then could help asking, “How is she doing?”

“She’s better now, but it hasn’t been an easy time.”

That wasn’t new to her, but Catra still felt her throat knotting up, “I’m sorry I hurt your daughter.”

“I can’t say I’m glad about that.”

Finally, the reason for the call came clear in Catra’s mind. He wanted to give her a piece of his mind. She knew it would happen sooner or later. Catra had hurt his only daughter. If she had been in his shoes, she would have already paid for it. However, for this job, she thought it would be her mother-in-law Angela, not him. Anyway, Catra wouldn’t stand for it, not today.

“So what? You thought it was a good day to settle the score,” she replied defensively, feeling her muscles tense up.

“No, I don’t believe yelling at you or insulting you will help Glim,” Micah said calmly.

“Let me guess. Angela doesn’t share your point of view?”

“I can’t speak for my wife, but I think it would be better if you don’t run into her too soon.”

Through her infidelity, Catra had not only lost her wife, but also her family. Nearly eight years earlier, her first meeting with her

future in-laws had been awkward. Catra had been nervous and hadn't known how to act. After all, she thought they would be everything she didn't like: posh, well-off, and condescending. However, her parents-in-law had treated her like their own daughter. Catra had found, to her own surprise, a family for the first time in her life.

"I suspected as much," she snorted and pinched the bridge of her nose. "But seriously, what do you want?"

"Nothing I haven't already said. I'd like to know how you're doing," he said sincerely. "It's a significant day and I know you never have many people around you."

From anyone else, Catra would have taken this as pity. But she knew it was just his way. Over the years, Micah had grown fond of her. "No, it's not the best day," she said honestly, shrugging. "But I'm out hiking with friends and it's sunny."

"That's a way to spend your Sunday. You seem to be doing well?"

It was a broad question. She couldn't deny she missed Glimmer, but she didn't want to mope around any longer. The last few months had been difficult, and she still had good and bad days. As she looked around at the splendid view and at her friends meditating nearby, she felt summer was bringing her some relief.

"I'm better too," she said in a firm voice. "I've made a bunch of mistakes. But believe it or not, I never meant for things to turn out this way."

"I'm old enough to know things don't always turn out the way we planned."

"I can't argue with that. You're pretty old."

She and Micah had always discussed things freely and she was finding that wasn't all lost. It was comfortable, like coming back to an old home. When she and Glimmer visited their family, Catra had enjoyed these simple conversations. Of course, it wasn't the

same, and she knew it never could be. However, she would take what she could get.

He let out a laugh, then fell silent for a moment, “Did you know I was married? Before Angie, I mean?”

“Really?” She cocked her head. “I didn’t know that.”

“I don’t really talk about it. I was barely twenty. We were young, in love, and stupid. Our marriage hardly lasted a year. However, I learned a lot about myself, and then I met Angie a year later.”

Pushing around some stones on the ground with her feet, she sighed, “I get your point, Micah, but I’ve not been in my twenties for a while.”

“Some people are sharper or more precocious than others,” he laughed.

“Don’t try to be clever with me,” she retorted with a slight smile.

They chatted about each other’s latest news for a few minutes. However, they avoided the more sensitive topics. During the call, her friends finished meditating and started unpacking their lunch. Scorpia opened a bottle of wine and waved a glass at Catra with a broad smile.

“Thank you for calling, and- Well, thanks,” Catra finally said, as their discussion seemed to come to a natural end.

“You’re welcome,” Micah said in a warm voice. “And you can also call if you want to chat. I mean it, really.”

As she hung up, she walked toward her friends with mixed feelings. A glass of white wine was already waiting for her and she grabbed it. After a two-hour hike, meditation, and an emotional call, she deserved to simply enjoy this time with her friends. They raised their glasses to the view. It was a complicated day for her, but it could have been much worse.

Stop Moping Around

As the train followed the valley, Adora gazed out of the window dreamily. The car was half-empty – it was a Saturday morning – allowing her to observe the landscape quietly. It was early autumn and the trees were beginning to turn brown, and the sunlight seemed duller. However, she recognized every little town they passed through and knew the name of every mountain she saw.

Every time she came back, nostalgia caught up with her despite herself. Certainly, the valley was just a collection of villages and it was a boring rural area. She had many bad memories here, but also some good ones. Besides everything, the place remained her hometown.

When the train stopped at Etherberg, she grabbed her backpack and got off. On the platform, she stretched her arms to wake herself up. She was glad to finally arrive after three hours and four different trains. Bright City was only a hundred kilometers away as the crow flies, but the mountain topography imposed its own rules.

Wandering around the town, she looked at the stores and greeted a few old acquaintances. Even years later, these streets remained her home in many ways, and she still knew every nook and cranny. She tried to come once a year, so she could see how the area evolved. Even though the atmosphere didn't change, there was always something new. Today, she discovered a new restaurant which hadn't existed a year earlier and had a quick lunch there.

After her troubled year, she found some relief in walking the streets full of old memories.

In the late afternoon, her way led her to the periphery of the town. Between a pine forest and a narrow river, a low stone wall marked the limit of the graveyard. She went in without a second thought. The place no longer gave her the intense sadness she

had known in her youth. After three decades, time and life had done their work.

The place was almost empty, apart from an old woman watering flowers on a grave next to the entrance. Adora nodded at her without a word. Her mother's grave was in a corner between two other unmarked graves. However, Adora didn't need a name to know it was the right place. She had brought a flower and placed it on the grave.

She contemplated the simple panel, eroded by time. Her mother had passed away when she was seven. It felt like a different life. Now, she remembered and saw her mother with adult eyes. After all, Adora was almost a decade older than she had been. Now, when she thought of her, she almost saw her as a sister – maybe even younger one. It was a strange feeling.

She stayed there for a while, thinking about her mother and her childhood. But she also remembered the last time she had visited, a year earlier, with Bow and their children.

Her mood was beginning to darken when she heard footsteps on the gravel. She glanced back her shoulder. A woman in a police uniform looked on from a few meters away. She was a bit shorter than Adora, with a tanned complexion and brown hair tied back in a braid.

"Rumor has it that a vagrant blonde is roaming the town," the newcomer said as she approached.

"So, you follow me even here," Adora commented, raising an eyebrow.

"You haven't moved for ten minutes. I was afraid you'd had a stroke or something. Fortunately, you're just moping around. "

"I'm not moping, Mara."

"Please, I can smell you moping from a mile away," Mara said, putting a hand on Adora's shoulder. "Come on, my shift's over."

Adora rolled her eyes but grabbed her backpack from the ground. They walked to Mara’s car, chatting about town gossip and their families. Mara was Adora's oldest friend; they had known each other since middle school. Even when Adora left the town twenty years earlier, they had kept in touch. They met up every time she came back and the brunette had visited her in Bright City a few times. Once again, she had invited Adora to spend the night.

“Thanks again for the invitation,” Adora said as they drove through the town.

“Don’t mention it, it’s always a pleasure to have you with us. Besides, Hope can’t wait to brag about the new guest room,” Mara replied, waving her hand.

“I’m just happy to be here. It’s a good break this year.”

“I get it,” Mara said, tapping her thumb on the wheel. “You could have called me.”

Adora let out a deep sigh and turned her head towards Mara. It had taken them just ten minutes to reach the subject. To be honest, it was longer than she had imagined. She had thought about calling her friend several times, but she didn't know what to say. She hadn’t talked about her divorce until Mara had invited her and her family, as she did every year.

“To say what?” Adora huffed, raising an eyebrow. “Hi, I’m divorcing my perfect husband because I don’t love him anymore. I also cheated on him for two years with a friend’s wife.”

“Why not? It’s a catchy opening,” Mara said, glancing at her with a knowing smile.

“I didn’t want to bother you with my mess.”

“I know you like to deal with things on your own, but don’t forget you’ve got friends. I mean the few friends whose partner you haven’t slept with.”

“Oh, shut up,” Adora groaned and rolled her eyes. “Have you finished your lecture?”

“For now, at least,” Mara said. “Listen, you can relax and unwind tonight. Netossa and Spinnerella are joining us for dinner.”

“Yeah, I’m sure Tossa will be really subtle about it.”

The town wasn’t large, so the ride to Mara’s house only took only a few minutes. When they arrived, Mara’s wife, Hope, had already set out appetizers on the table in the backyard. She always seemed such a perfectionist when hosting guests. Hope was a tall, elegant woman with a fair complexion and long, dark hair. Her black jeans and sky-blue shirt highlighted her slender silhouette.

Adora greeted her warmly, then took a box of chocolate for the couple out of her bag.

After the inevitable guided tour of their new guest room, they sat down at the table. Her hosts opened a bottle of wine and they started to chat. The place was peaceful, with stunning views of the mountains. Adora genuinely enjoyed just being with old friends.

About half an hour later, Netossa joined them. The woman seemed cheerful as she greeted Adora warmly. She was short and athletic. Her short, silver-dyed hair contrasted with her dark complexion. Her eyes were sharp behind her salmon-colored eyeglass.

“Spinnerella didn’t come with you?” Mara asked, walking out of the house with an empty glass for the newcomer.

“She’ll come later. She needs to close the store and drop the kids off at my parents’,” Netossa said, before immediately turning to Adora with a wry smile. “So, you screwed up.”

“Rude,” Adora commented, frowning at her friend. The words sounded rude, but she knew there was no malice behind them. Then she glanced at Mara, “News travels fast.”

Mara shrugged with a smile as she filled the glass, “I didn’t know it was a secret.”

“Rude, but true,” Netossa added, grabbing the glass with a smile.

Adora missed this kind of banter. After all, it had been a while since she had enjoyed time with friends. Her separation didn’t leave her much free time and most of her close friends in Bright City were also friends of her ex-husband, so her social life had been deeply disrupted.

Their discussion continued with laughter, bantering, and gossip.

"So, what does she look like?" Tossa asked as she began sipping her second drink.

"Who?" Adora asked, raising a puzzled eyebrow.

"Gosh Dora, the chick you got divorced for."

"I didn’t get divorced for her,” Adora corrected, shaking her head. “The situation is just-"

"Whatever, we just need some juicy details to brighten up our evening."

After a few more requests, Adora gave up and picked up her phone to find some pictures. Her friends browsed the few images with appreciative comments. This didn’t surprise Adora; Catra was naturally charming. She felt strangely proud, but she quickly pushed the feeling away.

"She looks stern but hot," Mara commented, as she handed the phone back to Adora. Hope gave her a suspicious look, so she added, "I'm just saying!"

"Yeah, she has a strong character, but she’s also very nice," Adora said with a dreamy smile.

"Brunette with character. Your taste hasn’t changed,” Tossa said with a wink and a smug smile.

Adora rolled her eyes, "Please, we dated for about three weeks in secondary school."

"Yet I remain the model of all your relationships," Tossa said with a smirk, pointing at herself. “But look at me, I can’t blame you.”

“Oh, shut up,” Adora huffed, laughing sincerely .

Her friend asked her lots more questions about her relationship with Catra. The drink probably helped her to speak freely, but she felt a sincere relief. She avoided answering the inevitable indiscreet questions, as maintaining a certain reticence. For the first time, she could talk about her relationship and share this important part of her life with someone.

"Why didn’t you not invite her this weekend?" Hope asked, as she opened a second bottle.

"We're not together anymore," Adora shook her head. Well, if they had ever been ‘together.’

"Why?" Tossa asked, holding out her glass for Hope to fill. "You divorced for her, after all."

"Again, I didn’t get divorced *for* her. Besides, she’s still married, or at least I think she is," Adora said, fidgeting absently with her glass.

“Dora, you’re clearly in love with her. You should know if there’s still a chance, at least,” Tossa commented, cocking her head.

It wasn’t that simple. Catra certainly had enough to deal with without a clingy lover. After all, Adora had started this whole mess in the first place; she was the cause of her friend’s trouble. If Catra had the opportunity to save her marriage, she wouldn’t stand in her way.

"What, should I text, ‘Hi, I dream about you every night. Call me if you’re divorced?’,” Adora said half-seriously, running a hand over her face. The wine really seemed to be working on her.

"You should,” Mara replied, grabbing an appetizer. “It’s clumsy and a bit desperate, but that’s more your way,"

“Thanks, I don’t know what I’d do without your precious advice,” Adora said sarcastically.

“No, seriously, maybe she’s hoping for that kind of text.”

Even though she had fantasized about it a few times, the idea was highly improbable. Her and Catra’s breakup seemed inevitable in the midst of all this mess. She didn’t even know if the word ‘breakup’ even fit their relationship. They had never talked about it.

“I doubt it,” Adora finally said, shaking her head slowly .

“You can’t know for sure,” Mara insisted with a serious look.

“No, I don’t.”

A Simple Blunder

Three years earlier

As soon as Adora opened her eyes, she felt her head pounding. Her mouth was dry and a shiver ran through her body. She tossed and turned in bed, trying to find a position that would keep her head from arching. Though the battle seemed lost, she still wouldn't get up.

The blind was closed, but she could see the sunlight outside. She instinctively grabbed her phone from the nightstand and looked at the time. It was already mid-morning. She hadn't slept so late in years. Looking around, the bed and the room were empty, but she could hear Bow and the children in the living room. When she finally stood up, her whole body seemed in pain. This hadn't been her plan for Saturday.

The day before, she had stopped off unexpectedly at a pub after work with a few colleagues. After all, it was her birthday and the end of the week, so it seemed a good idea to have a drink and relax. That drink quickly became two, then three, and probably many more. It hadn't been the plan for the night. With her head pounding, she truly regretted having drunk so much in the moment.

The sunlight hurt her eyes as she pulled up the blind. However, when she opened the windows, the fresh spring air was a relief. Her clothes from the previous day lay on the floor next to the bed and her shoes were discarded in a corner. She let out a deep sigh and ran a hand over her face.

After a quick shower, her head wasn't any better, but she was at least a bit more awake. She put on comfortable clothes and left the room. She chatted briefly with Maia and Fynn, who were playing in the living room. However, their noisy game forced her into the kitchen where Bow was cleaning up after their breakfast. She slumped into a seat.

“I’m not offering you breakfast,” Bow said with a wry smile as he wiped a glass.

“Oh gosh, no,” Adora huffed, giving him a tired look.

“I guess a coffee would help,” he took an already-filled cup from the countertop and placed it in front of her. “You looked pretty tipsy last night.”

“Thanks,” she said, taking the cup with a weary hand. “I didn’t think I would be home so late. Did I wake you up?”

He laughed, leaning against the countertop. “Oh yeah, you woke me up and spent at least thirty minutes telling me about your evening. You were very talkative.”

She groaned and leaned forwards, resting the head on her hand. Her memory was a bit fuzzy, but she remembered a few images from their discussion. She finally sipped her coffee and the taste shook her a little, but it didn’t really help with her headache. Letting out a sigh, she hoped the caffeine would get her through the day.

“Sorry. If it makes up for waking you up, my head is getting revenge today,” she said with a slight smile.

“Don’t be sorry, it was quite funny. Besides, you’re allowed to relax sometimes,” he said with a supportive look. “Did you take something for your head?”

“No, that will pass.”

“Are you not supposed to be a pharmacist or something?”

“Oh, shut up, I’m fine.”

“Clearly, you’re looking perfectly fine,” he said sarcastically. ”At least you didn’t drive yesterday. We'll have to pick your car up from the hospital.”

Adora cocked her head and raised a puzzled eyebrow, then the memories flooded in all at once. She had texted Catra when they were at the pub. It wasn't uncommon; her friend worked in the same neighborhood, so sometimes she joined them for lunch or a drink. The start of the night had gone well. There had been a lot of laughter and discussion. The atmosphere had remained good all evening. Adora had only pleasant memories. Well, almost all pleasant. Catra had been much more sensible with her drinks and had offered to drive her home. Adora couldn’t remember all the details, but she had talked the whole ride. Most of the time, the brunette had simply nodded or scoffed at her, but that was typical Catra.

However, her memory of the last part was far too clear. When they stopped in front of her house, Adora had thanked her endlessly for the lift. Without knowing why, she had put her hand on the brunette’s forearm and caught her deep gaze. Her friend's eyes were always so moving. Catra had given her a perplexed look, then Adora had moved forward and kissed her. The brunette had quickly pushed her away fairly quickly.

Adora jumped to her feet as she remembered it, and said hastily, "I’m going to get something for my head."

"Yes, that would help," Bow said, as she left the kitchen.

She rushed through the house to her bedroom, and grabbed her phone. It was bad, really bad. Why did she do that? It had been, to say the least, totally inappropriate.

The drinks had really made her lose her mind. Adora had given in to an impulse. The day before, Catra’s beautiful eyes had looked so shiny in the car. Besides, Catra was so kind behind her harsh attitude, and it was always easy to talk to her about anything.

Anyway, she had kissed her friend, her best friend's wife. It was a mistake, a stupid mistake, which she had to fix as soon as possible. She was many things, but not a coward. She had to take

responsibility and apologize for her behavior. However, a knot grew in her stomach as she called Catra.

Catra picked up after a few rings, and said in a high-pitched, sarcastic voice, “Hey Dora, I hope waking up wasn't too difficult?”

Words seemed to get stuck in Adora’s throat, now that she was talking with her friend. “Hi, yeah, I’m a little tired,” she stammered after a silence. “I wanted to thank you for driving me home yesterday.”

“That’s ok, you obviously weren’t in condition to drive.”

“Yeah, I drank too much,” Adora said with a slight laugh, then continued in an awkward voice, “I also wanted to apologize for the end of the evening.”

There was a long silence on the other end of the line and Adora felt a lump form in her throat. Pacing up and down, she rubbed the back of her neck uncomfortably. Her head was still pounding, and a shiver ran down her spine.

“Yeah, I guess we should discuss it,” Catra finally huffed.

“Listen, I was drunk. I’m really sorry,” Adora said hastily. “I don’t want to make things awkward between us. Can we forget about it?”

Catra let out a deep sigh before saying in a serious voice, “I think it would be better for everyone. I get that you were drunk, but you can’t do that kind of thing.”

“I know, I know, I’m sorry. It was a mistake. Could you not mention it to Glimmer, please? I’m not asking you to lie to her, but I don’t want to make the situation worse.”

There was another silence, but the answer was more relaxed, “Of course, I had no intention of mentioning it to her. She’ll blow things out of proportion, you know her.”

“Thanks. I was afraid to be honest. I don’t know why I did that.”

Adora felt a weight leave her chest as the situation seemed to resolve itself. She sat down on her bed and ran her hand through her hair. Fortunately, Catra was understanding. Adora had never done that before and certainly never would again.

“Don’t worry,” Catra said in a friendly voice. “But are you okay?”

“Not really, I feel like my brain wants to get out of my head,” Adora huffed, pinching the bridge of her nose.

“I can imagine,” Catra said with a laugh. “But I mean in general with Bow and everything, because you talked a lot in the car yesterday. You didn’t seem-”

“No, no, I’m fine.”

She was perfectly fine. After all, her children were the light of her life. Her husband was attentive, supportive, and trustworthy. Bow had been her first serious relationship, her first love. She had nothing to complain about. Sure, their marriage wasn’t the same as it had been, but that seemed normal with the years and the children.

Catra simply hummed, unconvinced.

“Sometimes, there is just a lot to deal with,” Adora clarified in a defensive voice.

“If you need to talk, I’m sure Perfuma could recommend a couples’ counselor or someone. It’s-”

“Stop it!” Adora said, raising her voice and standing up sharply. “It’s nothing like that. I was drunk. There’s nothing to talk about.”

She didn’t want to talk or to think or anything about it. She and Bow were fine and didn’t need any kind of counselor. Mistakes happened. There was nothing to read into the situation. The brunette was beautiful, smart, and made her laugh, so Adora had

given in to a stupid urge to kiss her. However, it was over, absolutely over.

“Anyway, it’s not my business,” Catra said in a frustrated voice.

“Sorry, I didn’t mean to yell at you,” Adora sighed and sat down again. “But I’m fine, really.”

“Okay, let’s forget about last night. Do you have time for lunch on Tuesday or Wednesday?”

“Tuesday sounds good. We could meet at noon in front of the hospital.”

Adora agreed, then she hung up. She then dropped her phone on the nightstand and rubbed her temples to calm her headache. At least, the kissing problem had been settled, so she could forget about it. Though the call had been a relief, it had left her with conflicting feelings. Getting up, she shook off the thoughts and walked to the bathroom to find some painkillers.

Missing Her Laughter

After several minutes of searching, Adora finally found the paprika. She had crossed the spice department a couple of times, pushing her cart, before stopping in front of the right shelf. Checking her shopping list, she was glad to have almost completed her daily shopping. There were still some fresh vegetables and yogurt to find. The kids would be with her for the week, so she needed to stock up.

Saturday, early in the morning, was a good time for errands. The supermarket was still half-empty and she didn't have to waste much time. After all, she had a busy morning ahead of her. Take her groceries home, do some housework, and finally head to her gym. Since it was the beginning of December, she wanted to stay in shape before the high-calorie end-of-year period.

As she grabbed the fruit yogurts, her plan seemed on track. However, it suddenly went off the rails as she pushed her cart toward the vegetable section. She froze when she spotted a brown-haired woman in front of the tomatoes. The brunette was frowning in the cutest way Adora had ever seen as she examined a tomato in her hand.

Adora felt a knot in her throat. Catra was just a few meters in front of her. After a few seconds, she pulled herself together, then abruptly turned her cart to hide behind a shelf of milk, though she couldn't help looking at the brunette.

Adora probably looked a little creepy, checking out the brunette while she hid. However, a wall of milk seemed to be the perfect protection. Adora scanned the vegetable section, but Catra seemed to be alone.

Twisting on her feet, she wondered what she should do. She knew what she wanted to do, but she wasn't sure it was right. Was it inappropriate to greet her? Despite everything, they were, or had

been, friends. It was perfectly reasonable to say hello to a friend, wasn’t it?

She might have ruined Catra’s marriage. But there was nothing to be nervous about, absolutely nothing. However, as her friend Mara had pointed out, Adora didn’t know. There was only one way to find out. She shook her head and took a deep breath, then pushed her cart toward the tomato rack. The weight in her stomach increased as she got closer. Catra was still examining the tomatoes when she stopped behind her.

”That looks like a really captivating tomato,” Adora said, voice as relaxed as possible given the situation.

Catra stiffened, as she turned her head, her eyes wide, “Hey.”

For a moment, they stared at each other in awkward silence. The lump in Adora’s throat seemed to grow larger with every second.

Catra was the first to compose herself and said uncomfortably, “So, you’re running errands?”

“Yeah, I needed some supplies. It’s my week with the kids.”

“Your week?” Catra said in a puzzled voice, cocking her head.

"We swap every week. Joint custody. You know, with the divorce and everything. We had to find a system. Of course, it's not ideal, but the children seemed to adapt. However, we've had to buy everything twice, now they have two homes," Adora said without taking a breath.

After their awkward start, she was relieved to reach a more tangible subject. Now, she could do one of the things she did the best: ramble. She explained her new daily life in detail, waving her hands. Catra looked at her uncertainly at first, but the brunette eventually broke into a slight smile. Adora couldn’t help thinking about how much she had missed it. As she spoke, she studied the brunette. Catra hadn't changed much since spring. Her hair was just a tad longer.

When Adora finished talking, Catra remained quiet for a while, still looking at her with soft eyes. Finally, she shook herself and put on a neutral face. "That’s a big change for everyone in the family. I’ve also experienced divorce first hand," she said, slowly nodding.

"Oh, that's great," Adora blurted as her eyebrows jumped up on her forehead.

Catra frowned at the words, looking at her in surprise.

"I don't mean great like *great* ," Adora corrected, raising a soothing hand. "It's just funny we're in the same situation. But, of course, not really *funny* , you know what I mean?"

"I guess."

Obviously, great was exactly what Adora meant. It was a great thing Catra wasn't married. It was great they were both free because it meant there was hope. Adora didn’t know exactly what kind of chance, or didn’t want to think about it too much, but Catra was talking to her, and that was already a lot.

“Anyway, it’s nice to see you. You look good.” Adora said in a warmer, more confident voice.

“Thanks, you’re looking great too,” Catra said in a hesitant way, then turned to her cart. “Well, I need to finish my shopping. But it’s-”

There was no chance Adora was going to waste the opportunity, “Do you have time for a coffee?”

The brunette hesitated, looking back and forth between the cart and Adora a few times, then sighed deeply, “Okay, I’ll meet you at the cafe next door after.”

Later, Adora was settled at a table with a cup of coffee in front of her. With the wooden furniture and marble countertop, the place looked like many other mall cafes without any real character. There weren't many people there, so she had found a quiet table

in a corner. When Catra sat across the table with her tea, Adora felt a mixture of anxiety and euphoria.

They remained silent for a moment, before Catra asked, “So?”

“So,” Adora repeated, a bit taken aback. She hadn’t prepared anything; the invitation was just a sudden impulse.

“What do you want Dora?”

“I’m not sure,” Adora said cautiously, before taking the plunge. After all, she had nothing to lose. “But I miss you.”

Catra grunted and pinched the bridge of her nose, “Please stop, this is inappropriate.”

“Inappropriate,” Adora said in disbelief. She couldn’t hold back a chuckle. “We’ve done a lot of inappropriate things, but I don’t think two divorcees having a drink is one of them.”

Catra sighed, “You know what I mean.”

Of course, Adora knew enough about the guilt to understand. Over the past few years, they had lied, cheated, and ruined their respective marriage. They had done many inappropriate things, in many hotel rooms, and in many positions behind their partners’ backs. However, she had already lost enough and wasn’t about to give up on this without trying her luck.

“So, what? You’d prefer us to pretend we don’t know each other just to punish ourselves?” Adora said, still smiling.

“You have a talent for making things sound stupid,” Catra said, shaking her head and absent-mindedly playing with her tea bag. “But that didn’t change the situation. I wrecked your marriage, your family.”

Adora cocked her head, giving her a puzzled look, “I didn’t remember you forcing me to do anything I didn’t want to.”

“It’s my fault Glim found out, and you wanted to stop it so many times, and-”

“And I came back every time," Adora interrupted, shrugging. “Please, we knew the risks. If you don’t want to see me, I understand. You can leave without looking for an excuse.”

“I’m not looking for excuses,” Catra said without moving.

They had played with fire and ended up getting burned. When they were meeting every week, Adora had wondered more than once whether it was worth it. She hadn’t found, and probably never would, an answer to this question. However, there was another question she thought she could get an answer to.

“At the time, you said you loved me. Was that just a lover's spiel?” Adora asked.

“Of course not, I was serious,” Catra replied, avoiding Adora’s look.

Leaning forward, Adora placed her hand on Catra’s without a second thought, “I never really answered properly, but I love you too.”

The brunette was a bit taken aback at first, then let out a snort. “Seriously, you saved your big declaration for a mall cafeteria. That’s a little pathetic, even for you, Dora,” she said in a sarcastic voice, but without pulling her hand away.

“Hey! I’m trying to be spontaneous.”

“That’s never been the best adjective to describe you,” Catra said with a high-pitched laugh.

When she heard the laugh, Adora felt a wave of warmth run through her body. She hadn’t realized how much she had missed the sound. At the same time, Catra’s hand under hers sent shivers down her spine. Adora wanted more – she wanted everything. She was dreaming of inviting Catra home at that very moment

and tasting the softness of her skin against her lips again. It was, of course, too much, too soon, so she pushed the idea away.

“Date?” Adora articulated awkwardly. Her throat seemed to be totally dry.

Catra raised a perplexed eyebrow, “What?”

“May I ask you out on a date?”

“We slept together for years, “ Catra said, rolling her eyes. “I think we passed that point long ago.”

“We’ve never been on a date,” Adora said, shaking her head. “We always hid away in hotels, but I want to go out with you this time.”

“I could find time for that,” Catra said in an indifferent drawl, but her eyes were intense.

As soon as she heard Catra’s answer, Adora’s mind went to planning their date. She already had a restaurant in mind. It was a lovely place in a ski resort nearby. She and Bow had been a few times over the years. However, she should book soon; it would likely be packed this time of year. Maybe they would even take a walk in the snow before their dinner to see the decorations. She also had to bring flowers. After all, it wasn’t a real date without flowers.

Adora was drawn out of her thoughts by Catra, who cleared her throat with an amused look.

“Fine, fine,” Adora said, unable to hold back a grin. “But I won’t be able to do it this week. You know I’ve got the kids, and-”

“Don’t worry, I can wait a week,” Catra said with a wry smile.

“Perfect, what about a week on Friday? I’ve already got a few ideas.”

“Sounds good, but I don’t want flowers or any other cheesy gestures.”

Adora tried to roll her eyes in an indifferent manner, “I wasn’t thinking of anything like that.”

“Sure.”

They chatted about lots of things for at least an hour – insignificant and important alike. Adora admired Catra’s every gesture and savored every word. She had missed all the little things more than she had expected. When they said goodbye, she felt a pinch in her chest, but she couldn’t stop smiling for the rest of the day.

A Great Consolation Prize

Pacing up and down, Catra examined her various closets and cabinets. She was sure it was somewhere in the apartment. Her move had been rushed and quite emotional, but she clearly remembered packing it. Rubbing her short brown hair, she looked around, trying to remember where she had put it.

In a flash of clarity, she went to the wardrobe near the entrance. She grabbed a box, which hadn't been open since she moved in, from under some running shoes in the bottom drawer. Her long burgundy coat was neatly folded in it with her other winter clothes. She only wore it for special occasions, and it seemed to fit the evening well. After all, it was her 'sexy coat', or at least that was what her ex-wife had called it.

She put it on, then walked to her bedroom to look at herself in the wardrobe mirror. Turning on her heel, she was quite satisfied. The coat matched her jeans, black sweater, and red scarf. It seemed an appropriate outfit for the night. A doubt crossed her mind as she contemplated herself again, but she pushed it away. She still had a few minutes, so she slumped down on her sofa to try to relax, dropping her coat and scarf next to her. When her phone rang, she frowned at the name on the screen.

"Hi Wildcat," Scorpia's voice was far too enthusiastic and dynamic.

"What do you want?" Catra replied.

"I wanted to wish you good luck for your big night. You're not too nervous, are you?"

"Why should I be nervous? Because it's my first date in ten years or because it's with the woman whose marriage I ruined?"

When Adora had bumped into her the other day, Catra had been surprised the blonde had even wanted to talk to her. Her unexpected confession and the idea of a date had sounded even

more absurd. However, she couldn’t deny the enthusiasm that had run through her at the proposal. Now, just a few minutes away from seeing Adora again, she couldn’t help feeling anxious. After all, their previous relationship had turned into a fiasco, to say the least.

“Stop it,” Scorpia said supportively. “You were so happy about it the other day. Besides, you know each other so well.”

“It’s not the same thing. We only had an affair,” Catra sighed, fidgeting with a button on her coat. ”She’ll have plenty of opportunities to see the kind of wreck I am this time.”

“Cut your garbage, you’re just freaking out,” Perfuma’s voice could be heard in the background. “The two of you went far beyond an affair.”

“I’m on speaker! Why am I on speaker?” Catra grumbled, pinching the bridge of her nose. “Scorpia, I don’t want to talk with your wife.”

“Adora already knows you’re a wreck, but still she asked you out,” Perfuma continued, ignoring Catra's protest.

Sometimes Catra didn’t like her friends. They were far too perceptive and knew her too well. She was about to give a retort when the doorbell rang. She jumped to her feet and turned nervously to the door, as though it would open on its own.

“I've got to go,” Catra whispered, walking towards the entrance slowly.

“Good luck. Don’t keep your date waiting,” Scorpia said in a delighted voice. “Call me tomorrow to tell me all about it?”

“No, Scorpia! I’m not sixteen.”

“Are you coming to meditation on Sunday?” Perfuma asked in a distant voice. “You can tell us all about it then.”

“Of course I’m coming,” Catra said absent-mindedly, hanging up her phone.

She waited a few seconds in front of the door without moving. She bit her lower lip, feeling a wave of excitement and apprehension run through her body. When she opened the door, Adora was there with a slight smile on her face. The blonde wore a sleeveless red dress which Catra loved under a large black jacket. She looked stunning in her outfit, with radiant blue eyes and cheeks rosy from the cold. Of course, she was five minutes early and had blue flowers in her hands. They looked at each other in silence, as though lost in their own thoughts. After a few seconds of staring at the blonde, Catra pulled herself together.

"You could have waited in the car," Catra said, stepping aside to let her in.

Adora shook her head and entered, looking around with curiosity, "No, no, no, I offer the full package for dates."

"Or were you hoping to head straight to my bedroom in your red dress?" Catra teased, as she walked over to the sofa to grab her coat and scarf.

"I never do that on the first date. I'm a lady."

Catra put on her coat, looking at her up and down, "Sure you are."

"You’re one to talk. I know your technique with the famous sexy coat."

"Who told you?" Catra asked, raising a surprised eyebrow.

"Your wif- I mean, Glimmer was my best friend. We talked."

An awkward silence fell between them at the mention of Glimmer. Catra looked at the floor as she slipped on her scarf. Rubbing the back of her neck, Adora suddenly seemed extremely interested in the apartment’s decor. There were so many delicate topics

between them. Catra just wanted to spend time with Adora without thinking about such things. After all, it was their evening.

Catra finally cleared her throat and grabbed the flowers from Adora's hand, "I told you I didn't want flowers."

Adora seemed to compose herself at that. "It was on sale, so I couldn't let them wither."

Catra rolled her eyes, "You're so cheesy. I'll handle our next date."

"I am, but you love it," Adora retorted with a smug smile. "Also, you're being a bit presumptuous, thinking you've already got another date."

"I am, but you love it."

In the car, the discomfort Catra had felt at first seemed to have completely disappeared. They talked freely about everything and anything. However, it had always been the same with Adora. Their discussion was easy and they seemed to understand each other without any difficulty. Catra had never been the talkative type – quite the opposite – but she could open up given the right moment. In many ways, it was a relief to her. The only other person who had ever given her that kind of comfort was Glimmer. But that part of her life was over.

Their ride to a nearby ski resort took twenty minutes. In mid-December, a thick layer of snow covered the roadside and the pines were totally white. When they arrived, the main street was decorated with lights and garlands. In the run-up to the festive season, the traffic was still light and the atmosphere peaceful. They parked in a small lot on the outskirts of the village, then walked to the restaurant at a leisurely pace.

The streets were full of decorated stores at this time of the year. Adora was glued to each shop window of moving Christmas decorations, her eyes shining with curiosity. The blonde's expression, focused so deeply on the little figurines, was almost ridiculous. But Catra couldn't help finding her beautiful.

"You look so stupid staring at that dumb stuff," Catra commented in a voice far too fond for the words, pointing at the window.

"Hey! They’re cute," Adora protested. "Don't worry, the next ones will be even dumber."

"Oh, I don't doubt it."

"It's our first date. Stop being so grumpy," Adora said, taking Catra's hand with a faint smile.

It was cheesy, but Catra couldn’t help but enjoy the moment – not the cheesy part of course, but simply being there with her.

When they found the restaurant, Catra was pleasantly surprised. The place looked cozy, without being too fancy. With Adora's perfectionism, the choice could have been much worse. She didn't fail to mention this to the blonde with a teasing smile. The interior was wooden, in typical chalet style.

It was clearly the kind of place Catra liked. The atmosphere was relaxed with light music, and their table was in a quiet corner. The dishes, simple but tasty, matched the decor. Catra savored her rigatoni, while Adora seemed to enjoy her risotto. However, Catra enjoyed Adora's presence even more.

As friends and lovers, they had shared many lunches, dinners, and other meals over the years. But this moment seemed different. For the first time, Catra didn't feel the need to hide in public. They didn't hide their intense shared gaze. She openly held her hand. Finally, they didn’t have to mask their relationship and that was an exhilarating new feeling. They chatted and laughed all through dinner.

The evening unfolded like a dream. However, during dessert, a shadow fell on the sweet moment in Catra's mind. After all, reality and its inevitable doubts rarely left Catra for long. After a mouthful of crème brûlée, she put down her spoon and tenderly took Adora's hand.

"Dora," Catra began in a pensive voice. "Where are we going with this?"

Adora shrugged and rubbed the back of Catra's hand with her thumb, "I think our date is going rather well."

"Yeah, but I mean… Our history. We didn't really start with the best way to build a healthy, trusting relationship, did we? I cheated on my wife."

"This may surprise you, but I also cheated on my husband."

"Can you be serious?"

Despite Adora's casual tone, their dubious history was the elephant in the room. They had already come a long way together, with many questionable decisions. Catra had needed to clear the air before going any further, before placing too much hope in what could be between them.

"I am," Adora said, squeezing Catra's hand. "We could work towards something healthy despite our past, or we could try, at least."

"Our infidelities don't give us the best references," Catra said with a slight smile.

"I think I slept with you because I was having problems in my relationship. But, if you can believe it, I don't think I would have done it with anyone else. It was you."

Aside from their relationship, Adora was probably the most honest and loyal person she had ever met. Of course, Catra believed her and knew all the doubts the blonde had struggled with during their shared history. She remained silent for a while, gazing into Adora's deep, tender blue eyes. She loved that warm look so much she could sink into it. She wondered how she could be so lucky to be there with her after everything.

“I loved Glimmer,” Catra said honestly, realizing this was the first time she used the past tense. “But I love you. It certainly wouldn’t have happened with anyone else.”

“So, will you give us a chance without any pressure, just a try to see where this goes?”

“I would like it”, Catra said after a while and intertwined their fingers. “We’re wrecks.”

Adora flashed a broad smile which seemed to light up the whole room, “Probably, but we can be wrecks together. We’re not a consolation prize.”

“Oh gosh no, I’d have found someone much better for that.”

“Hey, I could be a great consolation prize! ”

Leaning forward, Catra put her lips on Adora’s in a quick kiss. As they parted, they looked at each other with serene expressions. After the more serious moment, the mood between them immediately lightened. There were, of course, many doubts in Catra's mind, but she simply wanted to give them an opportunity. That was enough at that point.

For years, she had made so many promises and plans with her ex-wife, and then she had blown it all. She was tired of big words and eternal pledges. Trying was just fine for the moment. After all, amid all their mistakes, maybe there was something good to be built. They had plenty of time to try.

They finished their desserts, then strolled back down the street. The village was quiet at this hour, with only a few people milling about, looking at the decorations. Catra and Adora felt like they were in their own bubble. They walked slowly through the peaceful night, huddling together for warmth and to whisper to each other.

On the way home, there was a comfortable silence in the car. It was very different from their lively chat on the way to the

restaurant, but it was strangely cozy. Catra stared out the passenger window, deep in thought.

When she heard Adora yawning, Catra turned her head to tease her, “Don’t say I’ve bored you.”

Adora waved a tired hand with a faint smile, “Nothing personal, the week’s been long with work and everything, you know.”

“I get it. But you know what’s unfair?”

“Unfair?”

Looking at the blonde, Catra hesitated for a few seconds. Tapping absent-mindedly on her chin with a finger, she scrutinized the blonde. She knew what she was wanting for but didn’t want to push anything. The evening had been so nice so far. Taking a deep breath, she decided to try her luck.

“Yeah, you’ve seen my new place, but I don’t even know where you live,” Catra complained suggestively, with a knowing look.

“No problem, you could come over next time or we could have lunch-” Adora stopped when she glanced at Catra, meeting her intense gaze. Then she stammered clumsily, “I mean, yes. That is totally unfair. I’ve got to show you my apartment, because you deserve to-”

Catra snorted, “Oh gosh, you’re so dense sometimes. It’s not even fun flirting with you.”

“No, no, I just wasn’t ready. You can start again.”

Catra rolled her eyes, while Adora insisted she was totally ready. They bantered about Adora’s lack of flirting skills until Adora parked the car in front of her building. They headed for Adora's condo, holding hands and whispering tenderly. For the rest of their night, Catra enjoyed demonstrating that Adora wasn’t quite the lady she claimed to be after all.

Offering All the Hassle and Drawbacks

Adora smelled the scent of spring as she made her way home on her bike. When the weather started to warm up, she liked to commute in the peace and quiet sometimes. After a long winter, the mild spring days were always a relief. The atmosphere seemed totally new and different. The smells were fresh and the colors bright, the bird singing again.

Adora liked to ride slowly and make the most of the journey after a long day’s work. Of course, it was easier when she didn't have her kids. Those days looked like an endless race. As much as she missed Maia and Fynn, she loved these moments during her weeks alone.

Well, to be honest, she wasn't really alone. For the past few months, she and Catra had practically been living together when her children were at Bow's. It wasn’t official, but they usually spent the week in one apartment or the other. Without any discussion, things had simply fallen into place that way. This week, they were both staying at Adora’s.

Adora was pleased – more than pleased. Everything in her life seemed as fresh as spring, literally and metaphorically. Passing a flower store, she stopped on a whim and bought a bunch of lilacs. Catra would call it sappy or whatever, but she knew the brunette loved these little gestures. With the flowers on the pannier rack, she finished her ride, imagining Catra's reaction with a faint smile.

When she got home, Catra was sitting at the living room table, talking on her phone. She nodded at Adora with a slight smile as soon as she spotted her.

"You can’t get younger every year," the brunette said with a mocking voice. "Yeah, I know. I’m not getting any younger either."

Adora looked at her, raising an eyebrow, wondering who Catra was talking to. She walked over to the table and placed the flower

in front of the brunette.

Catra took the bouquet carefully, raising a questioning eyebrow. Then she smelled it, still talking on the phone. She glanced at Adora with a smirk and rolled her eyes exaggeratedly. Adora held up her hands and shrugged with a broad smile.

After the non-verbal complaint from Catra about the bouquet, she finally headed for her room to change into more comfortable clothes. The brunette was still talking when she came back in her loungewear. She slumped onto the sofa, letting out a deep sigh of satisfaction.

“Yeah, lunch together on Wednesday sounds good. Happy birthday again,” Catra finally said as she hung up. Then she turned to Adora, waving the bouquet, “Why did I do to deserve this?”

It took Adora a few seconds to realize Catra was talking to her, “Oh, you didn’t have to do anything special.”

“As cheesy as ever,” Catra snorted in a bored voice, but smelled the flowers again.

Glancing at her, Adora couldn’t hold back a grin, “You mentioned a birthday. I forgot someone’s birthday, didn't I?”

"No. It’s just Micah.”

Adora raised an eyebrow as she didn’t immediately place the name. After a few seconds of reflection, it finally came back to her. Micah, Glimmer's father? She didn’t know Catra kept in touch with her former in-laws. After the way her marriage had ended, it came as a bit of a surprise.

“You still talk with him?” Adora asked in a perplexed voice.

“Yes, why? Are you jealous?” Catra replied with a smirk. “I’m a people person, after all.”

“I can’t think of better words to describe you,” Adora chuckled sarcastically, glancing at her in disbelief. “I’m just a bit surprised you stayed in contact after everything.”

“They were my family for nearly a decade, so I’m glad one of them is still talking to me. And you still see Bow’s parents.”

It was true. Adora still met her in-laws from time to time. With Bow’s five siblings and parents all in the area, it was difficult not to bump into them occasionally. There were even occasional invitations from them. However, she wasn’t getting any ideas. The invitations were just a courtesy to the children. Without the kids, she had no doubt Bow’s family would have banished her long ago.

Adora shook her head, “They tolerate me because of the kids.”

“So, what? I haven’t earned the right to keep in touch because I haven’t given their family any heirs?” Catra said in a mocking way.

“I don’t mean it like that. It’s not-”

“Relax, I get it. It surprised me too, but I’m not complaining. I’ve salvaged what I could from this mess. Things don’t always turn out the way we imagine.”

This last point suited them both. Adora had never imagined living with Catra. Maybe she had fantasized about it, but she had never believed it was possible. Their history had been chaotic, and they had lost and hurt many people along the way. However, Adora had her children and kept a bond with her former family for them. After all, Bow would always be their father. So, she wondered whether Catra hadn’t lost more than she had, in a way.

“We never talked about it,” Adora began uncomfortably, standing up and walking over to the table. “But you and Glimmer wanted to adopt before the divorce, didn't you?”

“Well, we were trying to become foster parents,” Catra corrected, looking down as she fidgeted with the edge of the table. “We had

started the process. It was going well."

Clearing her throat, Adora sat down at the table next to her and took her hand, "We haven't been together long and you know I already have Maia and Fynn."

"Yeah, I noticed."

"The kids are already a lot," Adora continued, even more uncomfortable, but she didn't think she could avoid this topic. "I don't think I want any more. And I don't want you waste your time if you wish to-"

"It's okay, Dora. Don't worry, I don't want to start a family with you," Catra said, looking her in the eyes.

Strangely enough, though the answer was what Adora had hoped for, she was also disappointed. She had thought this sensitive topic would have given rise to more serious discussion. However, Catra had replied so resolutely and directly, doubts immediately arose in her. She even wondered whether the brunette still saw their relationship as a simple affair. After all, they went well together, but they had their own lives to deal with.

So, Adora began to do what she did best when she was uncomfortable rambling. "Of course not, why would you think about having a family with me? We're so far from that stage."

Catra squeezed her hand to stop her tenderly, "First of all, I was with Glim for eight years. Our family plan was ours. I don't want to project my past relationship onto ours."

"You sound just like Perfuma. Those meditation sessions seem to be paying off."

"I won't admit that," Catra said, waving her hand. "Besides, I've never felt the need to have a family in the common sense of the word. I don't agree with the idea that there's only one way to form a family."

Adora nodded slowly, “I think I understand.”

“One day, if we want something like that, we will find our own way.”

Catra seemed perfectly at ease as she explained her feelings in a calm voice, with a serene gaze. Adora had been worried about depriving Catra of something, but that didn’t seem to be the case. Even though the words were far away from her own feelings, she could understand it. After all, having a family had been one of her dreams since childhood.

Adora cocked her head as an idea occurred to her, “Would you like to come for dinner?”

“Um, I had in mind that we could have dinner later,” Catra said, raising a puzzled eyebrow.

“No, no, I mean with me and the children.”

“Oh. Oh!” Catra blurted with a stunned expression on her face, staring at her with wide eyes.

Adora moved her hand to Catra’s forearm, “No pressure, it's just an idea.”

Even though Adora understood Catra’s loner side, she didn’t really agree with it. Sooner or later, she wanted Catra to become an integral part of her family. Maybe it was still a little soon for her, or for the kids. To be honest, she didn’t really know, but she had the feeling it might be a good first step.

“I just wasn’t expecting it,” Catra said in a thoughtful voice.

“I’m not just a fantastic lover,” Adora said with a smug smile. ”If you want more, our relationship will come with all the hassle and drawbacks of my past.”

“Wow, you really know how to sell yourself,” Catra said, rolling her eyes. “I don’t want to rush into anything, but I’ll think about it.”

“Take your time. The proposition has no expiry date,” Adora commented with a supportive smile, rubbing Catra’s arm with her thumb. “Besides, I need to talk to them first. And Bow, too. I just want to make sure-”

“To make sure it won’t mess things up with sharing custody,” Catra finished, nodding slowly.

“Basically, yes.”

A comfortable silence fell between them and they stared at each other for a moment. For the first time in a long time, Adora felt fulfilled. After many years of immobility and confusion, her life seemed to getting back on track. When she looked at Catra’s intense eyes, it seemed she had made the right choice.

In No Position to Comment

When Adora parked her car in front of the house, a heavy rain was falling. It had started three days earlier and showed no signs of letting up, but it was typical of spring in the region. Looking out of the windscreen, she made a face and grabbed the umbrella from the passenger seat.

She got out of the car and walked to the house, which had once been hers, trying to avoid the puddles on the ground. After that feat of acrobatics, she managed to hide under the roof extension. Tightening her red raincoat around her against the cold wind, she closed her umbrella and shook it.

After she knocked on the door, Bow opened with a slightly tired smile. He greeted her with a yawn.

“Long weekend, was it?” Adora asked with a smug smile.

“Two kids stuck in the house for a whole rainy weekend,” he said, giving her a knowing look.

“I sympathize.”

Nodding slowly, he turned inside, “Maia, Fynn, your mom’s here.”

Distant, unintelligible answers came from inside the house. They continued to chat for a while, then she heard footsteps inside. A Fynn-shaped shadow passed them, greeting her loudly and saying goodbye to his father. He rushed to the car without avoiding the puddles, carrying his bag over his shoulder.

“I don’t even deserve a proper goodbye,” Bow complained.

“It’s raining, Dad, and I’ll see you in a week,” Fynn said, but he returned to hug his dad. Then he hurried to the car and got in.

"Maia, don't forget your new running shoes. I won't bring them to you if you forget," Bow shouted through the door.

"New shoes," Adora asked, raising an eyebrow. "We discussed being firm on this point."

"She's growing so fast she needs good shoes for her sports."

"Oh gosh, she tricked you, didn't she?"

"She didn’t. I'm unyielding."

Adora rolled her eyes and they bantered about it for a while. However, she wasn't really disappointed; she knew Bow too well. Their separation and divorce had been difficult for their children, though they had tried to ease the situation for them. Fortunately, Maia and Fynn seemed to be adapting well after a year. There were still ups and downs, but she and Bow couldn't complain. It wasn't perfect, but she was relieved to see that it wasn’t so bad. At least, their kids had learned to make the most of this new way of life quickly enough.

When her daughter came out, dragging her wheeled suitcase, she hugged them both and smiled. The first few weeks, when she cried during the weekend changeovers, now seemed far away. Complaining of the cold, Maia ran to the car to join her brother. On the doorstep, they talked through the children’s latest news and other practical matters.

"So," Bow finally said, yawning again. "I'll pick them up next week."

"Yeah, there’s one last thing I’d like to talk about," Adora said uneasily, looking at the car to make sure they weren’t being overheard. "I want to invite Catra to have dinner with the kids."

“Dora, we’re divorced. I don’t think you need my opinion on her,” Bow said, raising a perplexed eyebrow. Then he continued, sadder but without bitterness, shrugging weakly, “Especially when you didn’t even seek my opinion even before our divorce.”

She huffed deeply, pinching the bridge of her nose, “I don’t want us to have problems with sharing custody.”

“Do you expect me to say something like ‘I don’t want that woman anywhere near our children’?”

In many ways, she was afraid of exactly that, but she knew better. They had all resumed their own lives, but that was the point of divorce. However, she couldn’t totally erase the guilt of having caused the breakup of their family. As they finally found some stability, she didn’t want to take any more risks with it.

“Yes, something like that,” she said, looking at him with a slight smile.

“I can’t forget what she – you – did. After all, she was my friend too,” he said in a flat voice, letting out a deep sigh. “But it’s not about me. If you’re in a relationship with her, she’ll be part of your life. Besides, you know the kids like her.”

Adora nodded slowly, “Thanks.”

For a moment, she saw him as her old friend and partner again, always ready to support her. It was a strange sensation. She had loved him so much and they had been so happy for a long time. However, it seemed like an old dream, gradually fading after in the morning.

“I think we should talk to the kids together, so they’ll see it’s not a problem,” Bow said after a while.

“That sounds like a good idea,” Adora agreed, nodding slowly. “We could do it next week when you come to pick them up.”

“Yes, okay,” Bow huffed thoughtfully, staring into space. “So, you’re still seeing – Sorry, it’s none of my business,” then he hesitated a few seconds, “I’ve been seeing someone for a few months too.”

“That’s good. I’m happy for you.”

Bow seemed uncomfortable, running his hand through his hair, “It’s Glimmer.”

Looking at him in surprise, Adora was a little taken aback by the news. It was a surprising irony. She was genuinely happy for him and not really surprised he was in a relationship. After all, Bow had always been a people person, so she couldn't imagine him alone for too long. However, she wouldn't have expected it to be Glimmer.

"Oh, okay," Adora simply said, as she pulled herself together after the initial surprise.

"It started a few months ago, we didn't-" Bow began to explain.

"Hey, you don't owe me any explanations," she interrupted, holding her hands up.

"True, but I wanted to let you know. If it goes on, you'll probably bump into her sooner or later. But I think later would be better."

"I can imagine that."

Looking at him, she could help thinking he and Glimmer made a nice couple. But Adora felt a slight twinge in her chest at the idea. It wasn't jealousy or anything like that, as she was far removed from that kind of feeling for him. It was more like melancholy. This step was further proof her past life was over forever. She and Bow were building new lives apart.

"Maybe, it would be better to tell Catra about it. I'll do the same with Glimmer," he said, giving her an awkward smile.

"Yes, that would be better," she said, slowly nodding a bit lost in thought. Then she cocked her head with a smug smile and knowing look.

"What?"

"Remember when you and I joked about swinging with them? Maybe we're a bit psychic," she chuckled.

Looking at her with a deadpan face, he shook his head.

“It’s too soon to joke about that, isn’t it?” Adora said, as she caught his expression.

“Far too soon.”

“I get it,” Adora said with a short laugh as she turned away, opening her umbrella. Then she walked toward the car, waving her hand above her head, “See you next week.”

The drive home was pleasant, even though it wasn’t exactly quiet. Her kids inevitably fought with each other for some reason she didn’t understand. Then, her son had forgotten his sports shoes at his dad’s house – again. After all, the children had two homes, so this was an inevitable part of the logistical difficulties. She would pick them up during the week or Bow would drop them off. Their homes couldn’t be too far apart for the kid’s school.

Arriving home, Maia and Fynn immediately set their things in their rooms for the week. After a year, they were perfectly used to the process. Adora enjoyed spending this quality time with them. There was nothing exceptional about it: they simply had dinner, talked about their day, and spent some time together. However, she missed them so much when they weren’t around.

After her children had gone to bed, she slumped down on the sofa. Even though she loved them more than anything, it was still exhausting to move them between homes. Wrapping a blanket around her, she simply wanted to relax for the rest of the evening. As she watched a TV show, she felt something – or someone – was missing. Grabbing her phone, she instinctively called Catra.

“You’re already missing me,” Catra purred as soon as she picked up.

Adora couldn’t help but smile broadly at the sound of this voice, “I can’t deny it. After all, I haven't seen you since this morning.”

A snort came from the other end of the line, “You’re so sappy. It’s even hard to tease you.”

“What? It's been a long time. How was your day?”

“You know, the usual work nonsense, but I went jogging on my lunch break. How about you? How are the kids?”

The short answer didn’t surprise Adora. It was the brunette’s usual way. Catra didn’t always talk much, but she was an oddly good listener, at least with her. Tightening the blanket around her, Adora began to explain her day in detail. Just then, she would have loved to feel Catra’s warmth under the blanket, to hold her close. Those moments when they just shared their daily lives were sweet. However, there were also a few more serious matters tonight.

“I talked to Bow about the possibility of having dinner with you and the kids,” Adora finally said after a while, fidgeting with the blanket. “We’re going to talk to the kids about it.”

“Wow, you don’t waste any time,” Catra huffed. “No-pressure turns into full pressure.”

“No, it’s just the first step. It’s entirely your choice.”

“I hope so because I’m a popular woman. I’m not sure I'll find much time for that in my busy social life.”

“Oh, I’m sorry to disturb your thrilling appointment with your couch.”

As they bantered on the subject, Adora felt relieved. She didn’t want to push things, even though she had been thinking about it more and more lately. Her life seemed to be split in two, one week with her children and the other with Catra. They were the two sides of her new reality. One day, she hoped to combine the two parts of her life.

“There’s also something Bow wanted me to tell you,” Adora said uncomfortably, sitting up a little.

“What’s that? Did he send you to lecture me?” Catra snorted with laughter.

“No, actually, he's been in a relationship for a few months.”

“Okay,” Catra commented in a puzzled voice. “Congrats to him, but I don’t see what that has to do with me.”

“He’s with Glimmer.”

There was a long silence on the other side of the line. She could imagine how unexpected the news was for Catra. After all, she hadn't really had time to think it through herself. The silence became more and more uncomfortable as the seconds ticked by.

“Catra,” Adora whispered, beginning to worry. “Are you okay?”

“Sorry,” Catra finally said, clearing her throat. “I wasn’t expecting that. It’s fine. It’s just-”

“I get it. It surprised me too.”

“Anyway, it's good for them. Besides, we’re not really in a position to comment.”

“Indeed, I think so too,” Adora chuckled weakly, then asked, “Are you going to meditate this week?”

They both seemed relieved with this change of topic. After all, they would have plenty of time to talk about it later, if they wished. For the moment, Adora simply wanted to be with Catra, even just on the phone. They discussed lighter matters for a while, between laughter and whispered tender words.

When she hung up to go to bed, Adora felt incredibly lucky. Catra’s sweet voice remained in her head and her children were peacefully sleeping in their bedrooms. She definitely couldn’t complain. Things could have turned out much worse.

Epilogue - No Way to Rewrite the Past

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The weather was pretty good for jogging. It wasn't too hot for a summer's day, and there were a few clouds. Catra loved days like this, so she planned a long run through the forest. Walking along the sidewalk, she looked up at the nearby mountain to choose her path. She was wearing blue sports shorts, a red sweater, and her too-yellow sneakers.

She grabbed her phone from her running belt and looked at the time. In the late afternoon, she had plenty of time to run and still meet Adora for dinner. However, she still had one more thing to do before she was free for her run.

"Catra, I think I left my shoes at home," Fynn said, as he looked in her backpack.

"Too bad you'll have to go barefoot," Catra retorted in a serious voice.

"Yeah, too bad," Maia echoed mockingly, walking beside him.

Catra was walking them to their father's house. Bow lived only ten minutes away; she couldn't understand why Adora usually drove them.

Two years after her divorce, Catra's life was completely different. A few months earlier, she had moved in with Adora and her children. At ten and eight, the two kids were quite bearable, in Catra's opinion. More importantly, they seemed to tolerate her, and sometimes even like her. It wasn't always easy, but she tried to fit into this new situation.

"But I need my shoes for Saturday," Fynn protested with a disappointed expression.

“You know your mother and I are leaving tomorrow morning, so you’ve got no choice.”

“But I can’t-”

Catra snorted with a wry smile, “Don’t pout, I’ll have your mom drop them off.”

“Hey! That was mean!” he complained, frowning deeply.

Of course, she was being a bit mocking, but it was so tempting to mess with the kids sometimes. After all, every tale needed a villain. As a sort-of stepmother, she fitted the role perfectly. From the children's point of view, she probably had all the qualities required to play the villain. A new woman who came into their family to take their father’s place.

Catra would certainly look like that from the outside, not to mention her history with Adora. However, she was struggling to find a proper place in Adora’s family without pushing too hard. She was no longer a stranger, but not yet a full member of their family. But it was a good sign to be able to joke.

“No, she’s not. You’re just too gullible,” Maia commented, mirroring Catra’s smirk.

“See, your sister understands,” Catra agreed playfully, pointing at Maia. The girl was sharp and Catra could be a good role model in that regard. After all, the girl wouldn’t learn real sarcasm from Bow and Adora.

“I’m not. You’re just mean,” Fynn retorted, turning to his sister.

The two kids squabbled for a time and, as they continued to walk, their argument gradually faded.

“Catra, why won’t you come on Saturday? That’ll be so cool,” Finn asked as they reached the house.

“Yeah, there will be lots of flowers. We’ve chosen lots of colors,” Maia sounded thrilled.

“And Glimmer invited a bunch of people. She must know the whole town.”

“You should come,” Maia insisted enthusiastically.

Catra let out a short sigh.

The absence of her and their mother from their father's wedding had been a redundant question for weeks. Adora and Catra’s trip didn’t seem a very convincing excuse. However, the real answer was quite simple and honesty was the best way, wasn’t it? Their father was about to marry her ex-wife, and their mother had cheated on him with Catra. It was simple enough, but strangely, it didn’t sound like an appropriate reply for the kids.

Fortunately, Catra always had a secret weapon for this kind of situation, “You’ll have to ask your mom or dad.”

“You say that every time,” Fynn commented, adjusting his backpack.

“It’s because I’m mean, like you said.”

“No, you’re not. You’re great,” Fynn said, shaking his head.

“Sure, I am. But flattery doesn’t change my answer,” Catra said with a slight smile, as they arrived at the door.

Raising her hand, she knocked without a second thought. It wasn’t the first time she had walked them. She had already helped Adora a few times.

The first time she had come with the children, she had been nervous about seeing Bow. Of course, he had been cold, but courteous. She had no doubt he would have had a lot to say, but he knew how to remain civil. It was much better than she could

have hoped. After all, he had once been one of her few friends, before she had stabbed him in the back.

When the door opened, it wasn't Bow standing there. Catra felt a chill run through her whole body as she saw short purple hair. At the same time, she had a lump in her throat and a twinge in her chest. She had spotted her a few times in town or as a shadow in Bow's house. However, she hadn't been that close to her or talked to her since their separation.

The children greeted Glimmer and said goodbye to Catra as they entered the house. The two women found themselves alone on the doorstep. They stared at each other without saying a word. Catra remembered those same eyes full of hatred and anger, but it seemed so far away. Today, they seemed to show only contempt.

After a few awkward seconds, Catra finally pulled herself together and said uncomfortably, "Fynn forgot his shoes for Saturday. I'll have Dora drop them off."

Glimmer crossed her arm over her chest and coldly said, "Okay."

"You look well," Catra commented again, as no one seemed able to move.

"Thanks."

It wasn't a lie. Glimmer's short hair was cut in an elegantly-fake mess. Even under her big T-shirt and jogging pants, Catra could tell the purple-haired woman was in shape. Maybe it was the preparation for her wedding or her new life, but she was radiant. She was far cry from the woman who came home exhausted after endless hours of work. Catra was genuinely happy to see her ex-wife so happy.

"Congrats on your wedding," Catra added, swaying on her feet. "I hope the weather will be better than during the last one."

Glimmer gazed at her for a while, then sighed and uncrossed her arms, “That won’t be hard. The rain almost flooded the tent. The weather looks good for Saturday, so we’ll be okay.”

Catra smiled at the memory of their wedding, “I hope so. The kids will probably tell me all the details.”

“Or Dad will.”

“You know about that?”

“Please, Mom noticed a long time ago. He’s not much of a spy,” the purple-haired woman said, rolling her eyes. “But whatever, if it makes him happy. After all, he always adored you.”

Catra nodded slowly, looking at her with a knowing smile. It was strange to be talking to Glimmer again. Catra knew every one of her moves and her way of speaking, and at the same time everything seemed different. She had loved her so much, but that seemed like an old dream. She and her ex-wife had been happy for a long time, and she certainly didn’t want to forget that. However, Catra’s old feelings had faded.

Things certainly could have turned out differently. In another world, they would already have been foster parents for two years. They would probably have been happy. Her life would have been totally different. Whatever, she couldn’t rewrite the past. Catra was genuinely happy and deeply in love with Adora, and there wasn’t more she could dream of.

Catra held her gaze for a moment, then said, “Fine.”

“Fine,” Glimmer echoed, staring at her pensively

“Good luck on Saturday. See you,” Catra said, turning and walking slowly away.

“See you.”

As she walked away, she didn’t turn around to look at Glimmer. A few seconds later, the front door closed behind her and Catra felt a strange sense of relief. Their discussion could have gone much worse. Catra walked along the sidewalk for a few minutes, deep in thought. It felt as though something had ended and she was turning over a new leaf.

Letting out a deep sigh, she grabbed her phone and called Adora. The blonde picked up after a few seconds. There were voices in the background as she greeted her.

“One second, I’m going to my office,” Adora huffed, as the background noise subsided. “Sorry, it’s a busy day.”

“You’re almost done. Then we’ve four days to ourselves,” Catra said supportively. “By the way, I delivered the packages.”

“You mean my beloved children.”

“I think so, but you know all rugrats look the same to me.”

Adora groaned on the other end of the line and Catra chuckled in her high-pitched way.

They bantered for a while longer before Adora finally laughed back. The discussion seemed to relax Adora a little in the middle of her busy afternoon. Catra couldn’t hold back a grin. She loved her laughter. It was probably one of the things she liked most about the blonde, among dozens others.

“Actually, your son forgot his shoes for the wedding at home,” Catra told her, as she bent down to tie her shoelaces, clumsily wedging her phone between her head and her shoulder. “Can you handle it? I’m on my way for a run.”

“No problem, I’ll take him his shoes *again,* ” Adora commented, then huffed deeply. “Then we'll be ready to leave in the morning.”

“I’m looking forward to seeing your hometown.”

“You just want to listen to my friend’s embarrassing memories of me.”

“Basically, yes, I always look forward to that.”

Last year, Adora had hosted her friends Mara and Hope for a few days. Catra had met both women on this occasion and they had gotten on well. This weekend, Adora and Catra would spend four days in Adora’s hometown. Catra was really looking forward to seeing where she had grown up. It was a way of discovering another side of her partner.

“For my part, I’m especially pleased to be far from the wedding,” Adora said, letting out a deep sigh.

Standing up, Catra snorted, “Don’t be jealous, your next one will be much better.”

“Is this some sort of proposal?” Adora teased her in a seductive voice.

"Please, I certainly wouldn’t propose on the week of our exes' wedding. I'm not that pathetic."

Her answer was followed by a too-long, awkward silence, and then Adora stammered nervously, "Of course not, who would propose on a weekend like that? It would be utterly pathetic."

"Oh gosh, Dora, are you kidding? Whatever, do what you want. I'll pretend to be surprised."

"Hey, I didn't mean-"

Catra hung up before the conversation could go further. Dozens of ideas immediately flashed through her mind. Grabbing her flask from her belt, she sipped absent-mindedly, lost in thought. The weekend promised plenty of excitement. She couldn't hold back a dreamy smile as she fidgeted with her flask. Finally, she shook her head to push all the thoughts away.

The weather was fine that afternoon and she had too much energy to burn. Everything else could wait. They would have plenty of time to savor it when the time came.

She looked up at the mountain. The ridge path seemed a good choice. It started out steep, before turning off into the forest. The route seemed appropriate, even though her legs would be sore tomorrow. Anyway, Catra always seemed to take the hard way. Putting her phone and water bottle on her belt, she looked back at the mountain. Then Catra started running with an irrepressible smile.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for your comments and kudos.

I hope you enjoyed the story. Infidelity and divorce aren't popular plots, but it was quite fun to write.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!